

Strait of Hormuz: A Citrini Field Trip

霍尔木兹海峡: Citrini 实地考察之旅

Analyst #3 on Assignment 3 号分析师任务简报



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APR 06, 2026 2026 年 4 月 6 日 • PAID • 已付费



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Introduction 引言

CitriniResearch's *raison d'être* is taking complex topics of interest for investors and explaining them in a way that's intuitive. That's why our work spans so many asset classes, and it's why sometimes we write in-depth sector primers, macroeconomic missives and, occasionally, hypothetical scenarios that result in us receiving death threats (only *semi-credible* ones).

CitriniResearch 的存在意义在于将投资者感兴趣的复杂话题，以直观的方式进行解读。这就是为什么我们的研究涵盖了如此多的资产类别，也是为什么我们有时会撰写深入的行业入门指南、宏观经济信函，以及偶尔会因为提出假设性情景而收到死亡威胁（虽然只是半真半假的那种）。

Talking about something confusing is what gets us excited. It's also where great investment ideas are born.

讨论令人困惑的事物总能让我们感到兴奋。而这，也正是伟大的投资理念诞生的地方。

The situation in the Strait of Hormuz is nothing if not confusing right now. So, CitriniResearch sent our incredibly capable field analyst – dubbed ***Analyst #3*** in order to avoid emotional attachment – on assignment to the Strait of Hormuz. Armed with a

fluency in four languages including Arabic, a Pelican case full of equipment, a pack of Cuban cigars, \$15,000 in cash and a roll of Zyn, #3 set out to fulfill the itinerary we'd planned in our Manhattan offices the week prior.

霍尔木兹海峡目前的局势极其扑朔迷离。因此，CitriniResearch 派遣了我们能力极强的实地分析师——为了避免产生情感羁绊，我们将其代号定为“3 号分析师”——前往霍尔木兹海峡执行任务。3 号分析师精通包括阿拉伯语在内的四种语言，带着一箱派力肯（Pelican）防护盒装载的设备、一盒古巴雪茄、15,000 美元现金和一卷 Zyn 尼古丁袋，出发去执行我们前一周在曼哈顿办公室制定的行程计划。

We figured we'd leave with an impression that was basically “The strait was closed or open.” We also were quite aware that the trip might be a flop and we would learn nothing at all. However, we came away with a much more nuanced understanding of the current environment and the transition to a multipolar world.

我们原以为离开时只会留下一个“海峡是开放还是关闭”的模糊印象。我们也深知这次旅行可能会以失败告终，最终一无所获。然而，我们带回的是对当前环境以及向多极世界转型过程更为细致入微的理解。

If David Foster Wallace were alive today, he'd be reporting from the bar in a beachside town on the Omani coast- taking notes on a napkin about the particular quality of silence in a hundred-room hotel with three guests, watching tankers drift towards, but never quite reach, the Strait of Hormuz. That's our inspiration here, if DFW was also

concerned with finding alpha.

如果大卫·福斯特·华莱士（David Foster Wallace）还活着，他现在一定在阿曼海岸边某个海滨小镇的酒吧里发回报道——在餐巾纸上记录着一家只有三名住客、却拥有一百间客房的酒店里那种独特的寂静，注视着油轮向霍尔木兹海峡漂移，却始终未能真正抵达。这就是我们的灵感来源，假如华莱士同时也关注如何寻找超额收益的话。

This is a story about the most consequential place on Earth right now — the fifty-four-mile passage between Iran and Oman through which the global economy flows, or doesn't. There was no shortage of alpha on the Strait, including concrete information on the new rules, being written as we speak, on how the Iranian Revolutionary Guard is deciding who can, and can't, pass.

这是一个关于目前地球上最举足轻重之地——伊朗与阿曼之间那条 54 英里长的通道的故事。全球经济的流动与否，皆系于此。关于海峡的超额收益机会（alpha）并不匮乏，其中包括关于新规则的切实信息——这些规则正由伊朗革命卫队实时书写，决定着谁可以通行，谁不可以。

Analyst #3 decided – against the counsel of an Omani border agent, the implicit counsel of God, and the extremely explicit counsel of two Coast Guard officers holding assault rifles – that he was going to the center of the most consequential waterway on earth, during a live war, in a speedboat with no GPS, captained by a man he met three

hours ago at a port inlet by pulling out a wad of cash. *For investment research purposes.*

分析师 3 号决定——不顾阿曼边境特工的建议，不顾上帝含蓄的劝诫，也不顾两名手持突击步枪的海警极其明确的警告——他要前往地球上最重要的水道中心。当时正值战争期间，他坐着一艘没有 GPS 的快艇，船长是他三小时前在港口入口处掏出一叠现金结识的男人。这一切，都是为了投资研究。

Here's the story. 以下是背后的故事。

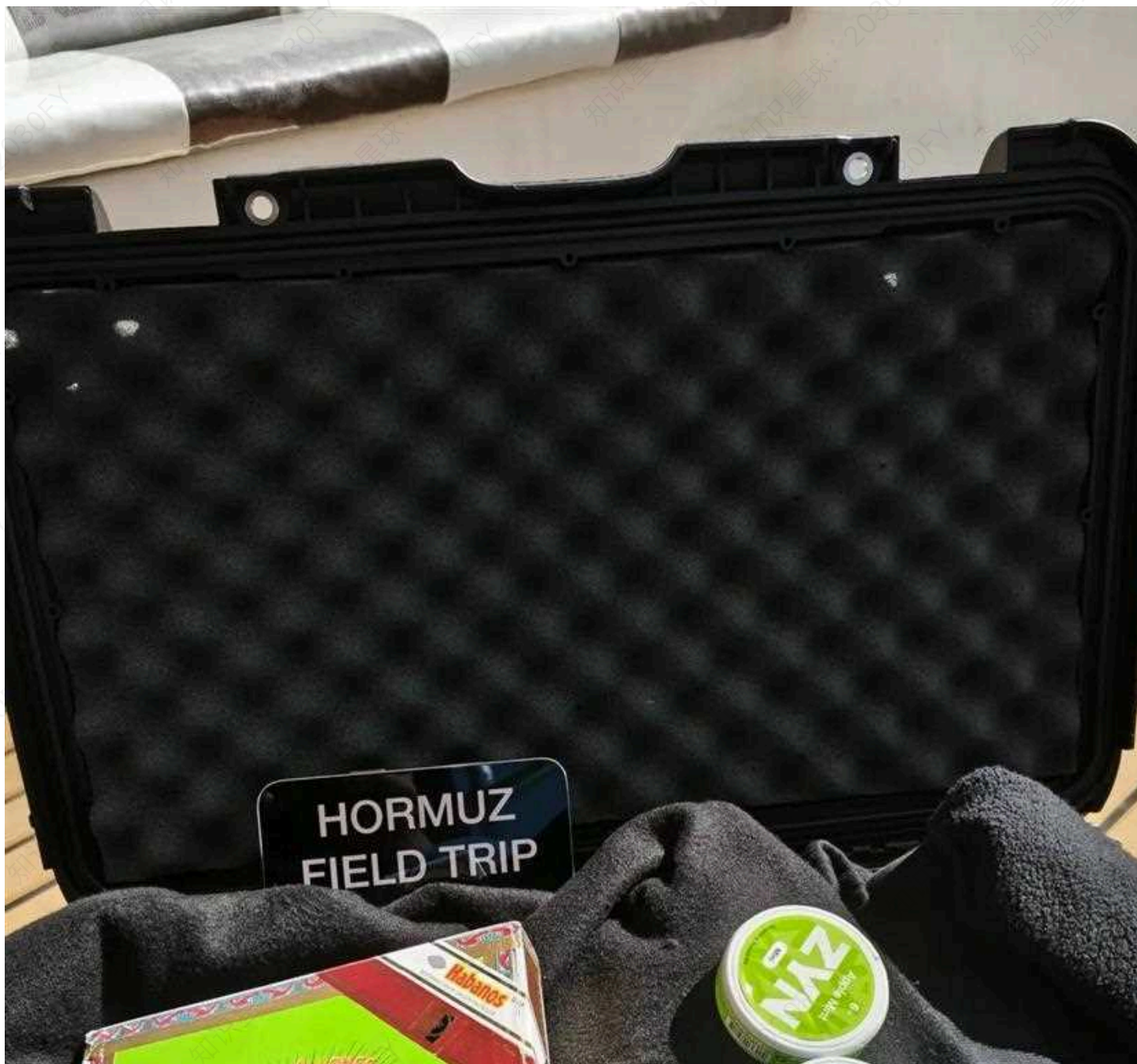
Into the Strait 深入霍尔木兹海峡

Before crossing into Oman, the officer asked Citrini Analyst #3 to sign a document. The pledge — preprinted, presented over tea at a desert checkpoint — was an agreement not to engage in photography, journalism, or info gathering of any kind within the Sultanate of Oman. He signed it.

在进入阿曼之前，官员要求 Citrini 分析师 #3 签署一份文件。这份誓约书是预先印制好的，在沙漠检查站喝茶时递了过来，内容是同意不在阿曼苏丹国境内从事任何形式的摄影、新闻报道或信息搜集活动。他签了字。

The officer then opened Analyst #3's rugged Pelican case to inspect it. What he missed: the gimbal, the microphone kit, the recording sunglasses. The assignment was on.

随后，这名官员打开了分析师#3 的坚固派力肯（Pelican）防护箱进行检查。他漏掉的东西有：云台、麦克风套装以及录像墨镜。任务正式开始。





On the other side, #3 talked his way onto a rickety speedboat with no GPS, defied advice from Omani officials to turn back, and rode on the open seas eighteen miles from the Iranian coast while Shahed drones flew overhead and Revolutionary Guard patrol boats ran patterns in the distance. He swam in the Strait of Hormuz smoking one of the Cubans he still had on him.

另一方面，#3 凭三寸不烂之舌登上了一艘没有 GPS 的破旧快艇，无视阿曼官员要求其折返的劝告，在公海上航行至距离伊朗海岸仅 18 英里的海域；此时，见证者（Shahed）无人机正在头顶盘旋，革命卫队的巡逻艇在远处按既定航线巡逻。他跳入霍尔木兹海峡中游泳，嘴里还叼着一根随身携带的古巴雪茄。

And then, he was intercepted by the Coast Guard, detained, and had his phone confiscated — before, eventually, making it back home to share everything he'd learned with us in an 8-hour

debrief session.

随后，他被海岸警卫队拦截并拘留，手机也被没收。最终，他设法回到了家，并在长达8小时的汇报会议中，向我们分享了他所了解到的一切。

This is what Analyst #3 found on his field trip to the Strait of Hormuz, from his point of view, with some key names, places and details of key events changed to protect the safety of anonymous sources. The quotes are based on his memory of the events, translated from the original Arabic. Which is the best we could do from an accuracy standpoint — considering #3's phone, and all of the notes and photos on it, is thousands of miles away, likely being combed through by the Omani authorities as we speak.

以下是分析师#3在霍尔木兹海峡实地考察中的所见所闻，均以其第一人称视角叙述。为保护匿名消息源的安全，文中更改了部分关键人物姓名、地点及事件细节。引文根据其对该事件的回忆整理，并由阿拉伯语原话翻译而来。这是我们在准确性方面所能做到的极限——因为分析师#3的手机，以及其中记录的所有笔记和照片，此刻正远在数千英里之外，很可能正被阿曼当局仔细搜查。

I. The Idea I. 构思

“What if I just went to the Strait of Hormuz?”

“如果我直接去霍尔木兹海峡会怎样？”

It's the kind of question that starts as a joke — the kind of thing you say at two in the morning to yourself in bed that doesn't survive contact with daylight, that joins the vast graveyard of schemes you were absolutely going to execute before you fell asleep and woke up a person with responsibilities again. But it wasn't 2AM, and we weren't in bed.

这种问题起初就像个玩笑——那种你凌晨两点躺在床上自言自语，却见不得光的话；它本该加入那座巨大的宏伟计划坟场，那些你睡前信誓旦旦要执行，醒来后却因回归现实责任而作罢的计划。但当时并不是凌晨两点，我们也没有躺在床上。

We were sitting in CitriniResearch's offices, in Midtown Manhattan, watching the biggest geopolitical crisis of the decade unfold on our phones. We watched the most liquid markets in the world fluctuate like meme-coins in a game of Trump Tweet-AP Headline pong.

我们坐在位于曼哈顿中城的 CitriniResearch 办公室里，看着手机上上演的这十年间最大的地缘政治危机。我们看着世界上流动性最强的市场像模因币（meme-coins）一样，在特朗普的推文与美联社头条的新闻乒乓赛中剧烈波动。

It was clear that nobody — literally nobody, not the analysts, not the correspondents, not the retired generals doing hits on cable news and least of all us — actually had any idea what was going on. Everyone was working from the same stale satellite imagery and the same unnamed Pentagon sources and the same AIS shipping data, which, as I

would later discover, was missing roughly half of what was actually transiting the strait on any given day.

很明显，没有人——真的是每一个人，无论是分析师、记者，还是在有线电视新闻上指点江山的退役将军，更不用说我们了——实际上都对正在发生的事情一无所知。所有人都在利用同样陈旧的卫星图像、同样匿名的五角大楼消息源以及同样的 AIS 航运数据进行分析。而我后来发现，这些数据遗漏了每天实际通过海峡的大约一半的航运量。

And, after all, wasn't it our job to make confusing investment environments less confusing? I wanted to do that, I had the connections to make it happen (at least some of it) and it would make for a pretty great story. So it was decided.

归根结底，让混乱的投资环境变得清晰不正是我们的职责吗？我想做到这一点，我也有人脉去实现它（至少是其中的一部分），而且这会是一个非常精彩的故事。于是，事情就这样决定了。

From Citrini's apartment in New York, we packed a Pelican case with a Xiaomi phone (that had a Leica camera with a 150x zoom, a souvenir from our trip to visit Robotics factories in China), an EPIRB, \$15,000 in cash, a gimbal and a microphone kit. We sat down and researched an itinerary, working backwards from the questions we most

wanted answered.

在 Citrini 位于纽约的公寓里，我们将一部小米手机（配备 150 倍变焦的徕卡摄像头，那是我们去中国参观机器人工厂时的纪念品）、一个全球海上遇险与安全系统（EPIRB）、15,000 美元现金、一个云台和一套麦克风设备装进了一个派力肯防护箱。我们坐下来研究行程，根据我们最想得到答案的问题进行倒推。

Proposed Strait Intel Trip: The Citrinerary

Day 0: Dubai - DIFC

- Source meetings: ship brokers, commodity traders, tanker analysts.
- Establish the baseline: what do the screens say?
- Speak with 'informed parties': determine expectations of military operations and shipping.

Day 1: Fujairah

- Boat at dawn: hundreds of idle tankers, billions in stranded cargo.
- FOIZ tank farm perimeter: which tanks burned, which are full, which grades are short.
- Ship agent row, Radisson bar:

Day 2: Khor Fakkan -> Dibba -> Khasab

- North along UAE east coast: Khor Fakkan container port absorbing diverted cargo.
- Cross into Musandam at Dibba: the tripoint where three jurisdictions share a bay.
- Arrive Khasab: Harbour at dusk, watch dhow movements toward the Iranian coast.

Day 3: Musandam Waters

- Full day by speedboat: Khor Sham fjord and Telegraph Island. Push to Kumzar - Iranian coastline visible, ~15km across.
- Negotiate with a fisherman: to approach the Traffic Separation Scheme.
- Conduct manual vessel count: against live AIS on the phone.

Day 4: Khor Najd -> Bukha -> RAK -> Dubai

- Khor Najd by 4WD: the only road viewpoint onto the Gulf-side shipping lanes. Observe Strait passage and boat activity, gather intel from locals, ground truth vs. Vortexa in real time.
- Bukha fishermen: with cross-strait contacts.
- Through Ras al Khaimah: dhow yards, creek traders, the physical infrastructure of the informal Iran trade.
- Back to Dubai.

CitriniResearch

I'd land in Dubai, speak with some informed parties I knew and contacts of CitriniResearch's, drive to Fujairah for some B-roll and information gathering at the oil terminal, then cross into northern Oman's Musandam province, get to Khasab, and try to get on the water.

我将先降落在迪拜，与我认识的一些知情人士及 CitriniResearch 的联系人进行交流，随后驱车前往富查伊拉，在石油码头收集一些空镜素材和情报，接着跨越边境进入阿曼北部的穆桑代姆省，抵达哈萨卜，并设法出海。



Credit: Dan DeLorenzo 鸣谢: Dan DeLorenzo

I started calling tourism companies trying to book a boat to Kumzar — an Omani village only accessible by sea, the closest inhabited point to the Iranian coast. It was an opsec mistake in retrospect — telegraphing my visit — but I couldn't think of another way to secure a ride. And on the bright side, from an opsec perspective, the identities I

was sharing were totally made up.

我开始给旅游公司打电话，试图预订一艘前往库姆扎尔（Kumzar）的船——那是一个只能通过海路到达的阿曼村庄，也是距离伊朗海岸最近的人类定居点。回想起来，这在行动安全（opsec）上是个错误——等于预告了我的访问——但我当时想不出其他办法来弄到船。不过从安全角度看，好的一面是我提供的身份全是编造的。

I tried something different every time I picked up the phone. Adventure tourist. Oil trader who wanted to count the boats going through. Real estate investor. (*"Bro, what do you mean I'm the first real estate guy you've heard from? This is the perfect time to buy! Land is cheap right now! Buy when others are fearful!"*) Didn't matter what I said on my end. What they said on the other end was consistent: "No."

每次拿起电话，我都会尝试不同的身份。探险游客、想要清点过往船只数量的石油交易员、房地产投资者。（“兄弟，你说我是你见过的第一个房地产商是什么意思？现在正是买入的绝佳时机！土地现在很便宜！要在别人恐惧时买入！”）无论我在电话这头说什么，对方的回答始终如一：“不行。”

Except for a single dolphin tour outfit. They said yes. Turns out: the IRGC can stop oil tankers. Dolphins are not intimidated. I had my ride to Hormuz.

除了唯一一家海豚观光公司。他们答应了。事实证明：伊朗伊斯兰革命卫队（IRGC）可以拦截油轮，但海豚可不吃这一套。我找到了前往霍尔木兹海峡的船。

We compared a list of all the contacts we had, and created a list of questions for each of them. Questions for shipping agents, maritime brokers, bunkering firms, government officials, military officers, local businesspeople intermediaries and everything in between. We'd gather as much information from people living and dealing with this in a real way as possible, then I'd go and observe the strait with my own two eyes from the tip of Oman.

我们对比了手中所有的联系人名单，并为每个人量身定制了一系列问题。这些问题针对航运代理、海运经纪人、加油公司、政府官员、军官、当地商人中间人以及介于其间的各色人等。我们将尽可能从那些真实生活并处理这些事务的人那里收集信息，然后我将前往阿曼尖端，亲眼观察海峡的情况。

I landed in Dubai and went straight to Fujairah. Anyone can make this trip, but it was still worthwhile. I saw the damage on the storage tanks from a previous strike, which was much less than I expected – a worker there told me that Ruwais got it much worse.

我在迪拜降落后直奔富查伊拉。虽然任何人都能走这条路线，但此行依然不虚。我看到了之前袭击对储油罐造成的破坏，程度比我预想的要轻——那里的一名工人告诉我，鲁韦斯（Ruwais）的情况要糟糕得多。

I was speaking with some people who were just doing their job, three weeks after a drone strike could have killed them. I managed to speak to a few people there off the cuff, from GPS Chemical and Chem Oil. They confirmed that operations were at about

30% of pre-conflict levels, but the port was back to operational. I wasn't going to finesse my way into accessing the terminal, so I drove back — just in time for the poker game I play whenever I'm in Dubai.

我正在和几位三周前险些在无人机袭击中丧命、如今仍坚守岗位的员工交谈。我设法与来自 GPS Chemical 和 Chem Oil 的几个人进行了即兴交流。他们证实，目前的运营水平仅为冲突前的 30% 左右，但港口已恢复运作。我没打算费尽心思混进码头内部，于是便开车返回了——正好赶上我每次去迪拜都会参加的扑克局。

No sleep since New York.

从纽约出发后就没合过眼。

I was in the kind of headspace where it's very hard to make money playing poker.

我当时的状态，很难在牌局上赢到钱。

II. The Poker Game II. 牌局

Every time I go to Dubai, I play in the same game.

每次去迪拜，我都会参加同一场牌局。

The guys at the table are the people I'd call if something went wrong anywhere in the Gulf.

桌上的这些人，就是如果我在海湾地区任何地方遇到麻烦，会打电话求助的对象。

The war, they all seemed to agree, was going to last way longer than people imagined. The next meaningful escalation, one predicted: strikes on Qeshm. Four days later, it came true. I was told to leave the region by the 6th — that was when they said, “shit is gonna pop off.” American soldiers had been amassing in the region at a much higher rate than reported, and the number of Iranian drone strikes seemed to have been much higher than anyone in the US was thinking. I asked what they were targeting, “Americans, brother. Americans and American infrastructure”. Seemed like a stupid question in hindsight.

他们似乎都一致认为，这场战争持续的时间将比人们想象的长得多。其中一人预测，下一次重大的升级将是对格什姆岛（Qeshm）的打击。四天后，预言成真了。我被告知要在6号之前离开该地区——他们说，那是“大事要发生”的时候。美军在该地区的集结速度远高于报道的水平，而伊朗无人机袭击的次数似乎也比美国国内任何人想象的都要多。我问他们的目标是什么，“美国人，兄弟。美国人和美国的基础设施。”事后看来，这似乎是个愚蠢的问题。

At some point I dropped the news: “I’m going to Musandam. I’m going to be on the strait.”

在某个时刻，我抛出了那个消息：“我要去穆桑代姆（Musandam）。我要去海峡前线。”

Everyone laughs it off. 大家都付之一笑。

Then they realize, for maybe the first time ever at that table, I'm not joking around.

“Bro, what are you talking about?” One guy wanted to come with me but said his dad would kill him.

接着他们意识到——这大概是席间的头一遭——我不是在开玩笑。“兄弟，你在说什么呢？”一个人想跟我一起去，但说他爸会杀了他的。

I asked if I could call these guys if something went wrong. They said they weren't sure it would make a difference. And then one of them started chuckling, before launching into a story about a situation he did not view as too dissimilar to this one.

我问如果出了什么差错，我能不能给这些人打电话。他们说不确定这是否能起作用。接着，其中一个人开始咯咯笑起来，然后开始讲述一个在他看来与此情景颇为相似的故事。

“There was an Emirati fisherman a couple years back who waded into Iranian waters unknowingly. The IRGC caught him. And then they brought him back to the Emirates,” he said, pausing. “In a barrel. In seventy-two pieces.”

“几年前有个阿联酋渔民，在不知情的情况下误入了伊朗海域。伊朗革命卫队抓住了他。然后他们把他送回了阿联酋，”他顿了顿说道。“装在一个桶里。被切成了七十二块。”

What do you say after that?

听完这话，你还能说什么？

Nothing, for a moment — until one of the other guys jumped in with a constructive idea. “I just bought Meta Ray-Ban glasses,” he said. “Want them?”

起初是一阵沉默——直到另一个家伙提出了一个建设性的主意。“我刚买了 Meta Ray-Ban 智能眼镜，”他说，“你想要吗？”

I said yes — and threw them in the Pelican case.

我答应了——并把它们扔进了 Pelican 防护箱里。

Poker wraps up around six in the morning. I hop in the car for the Omani border. My brain is mashed potatoes. Adrenaline from the idea of being on the strait is the only fuel.

扑克局在凌晨六点左右结束。我跳上车前往阿曼边境。我的大脑（Brain）像土豆泥一样混乱。唯一支撑我的动力，是即将抵达海峡这一想法所带来的肾上腺素。

III. The Border III. 边境

Dubai is still, in many ways, Dubai — Cipriani is still popping (albeit less popping than pre-crisis), all bellinis and meringue — but as you drive toward the border with

Oman the veneer peels off in stages. American soldiers where there used to be nothing, empty roads where there used to be traffic, and then a rickety desert crossing in the middle of nowhere that looks like it was built to process livestock and has been repurposed for humans.

在许多方面，迪拜依然是那个迪拜——Cipriani 餐厅依然热闹（尽管不如危机前那么火爆），到处是贝里尼鸡尾酒和蛋白霜甜点——但当你开车驶向阿曼边境时，那层虚饰便开始逐层剥落。原本荒无人烟的地方出现了美国士兵，原本车水马龙的道路变得空空荡荡，接着便是荒郊野外一个摇摇欲坠的沙漠关口，看起来像是为了处理牲畜而建，后来才改作人用的。

I made the mistake of snapping a picture — so sleep-deprived I was just holding my phone up, very obviously, as if I were a tourist at a scenic overlook rather than a restricted military border zone. The guard stared at me with the expression of a man trying to decide whether the person in front of him is a threat or simply an idiot. “Did you just... take a picture?”

我犯了个错误，拍了张照片——因为严重缺睡，我就那么明目张胆地举着手机，仿佛我是在风景名胜区的游客，而不是在军事禁区边境。警卫盯着我，那表情像是在努力判断面前这个人究竟是个威胁，还是单纯是个白痴。“你刚才.....拍照了？”

The UAE side had been fine — stamp, back in the car. The Omani side was not. I got directed into what I can only describe as the worst desert DMV on Earth: four

Pakistanis drinking tea barefoot, running back and forth between windows with the efficiency of people who've been doing this for decades and would very much like to continue doing it without incident. I'm standing there in a snapback and American Apparel sweatpants. Everyone ahead of me sailed through — stamp, gone. I handed over my Western passport and the two guards looked at it, looked at each other with the kind of wordless communication that is never good for the person being looked at, and one of them said, wait one sec.

阿联酋那边一切顺利——盖章，回车里。阿曼这边就不太妙了。我被带进了一个我只能形容为地球上最糟糕的沙漠车管所的地方：四个巴基斯坦人光着脚喝着茶，在窗口之间跑来跑去，那办事效率一看就是干了几十年、只想平平安安混到退休的人。我站在那儿，戴着平沿帽，穿着 American Apparel 的运动裤。排在我前面的所有人都顺利通过了——盖章，走人。我递上我的西方护照，两名警卫看了看护照，又互相对视了一眼，那种无声的交流对被盯着看的人来说绝非好事，其中一人说：等一下。

Ten minutes later a man came downstairs who starkly contrasted everyone else at the crossing — traditional Omani hat, pristine dress, the kind of person who smells expensive and speaks perfect English and is clearly operating several levels above the guys stamping passports. “Nice to meet you.” He pulled me into a back room with tea and began asking questions with the unhurried patience of someone who already knows most of the answers and is mainly interested in watching you try to construct

the ones he doesn't.

十分钟后，一个与关口其他所有人形成鲜明对比的男人走下楼来——戴着传统的阿曼帽子，穿着洁净的长袍，这种人身上散发着昂贵的香水味，说着完美的英语，显然比那些盖章的家伙高出好几个级别。“很高兴见到你。”他把我拉进一间备有茶水的后屋，开始不紧不慢地提问，那种耐心就像是一个早已掌握了大部分答案、只想看你如何编造他不知道的那部分答案的人。

He asked for the names of my parents. Where they're from. Where I work. Then, delivered with the same pleasant tone: "You understand the rules here against photography, journalism, and intelligence gathering." He asked about allegiances, the war, Israel. I told him I love everyone and I'm a tourist. He asked about my religion.

他询问了我父母的名字。他们来自哪里。我在哪里工作。接着，他用同样愉悦的语气说道：“你明白这里禁止摄影、新闻报道和情报搜集的规定。”他问及了政治立场、战争以及以色列。我告诉他我爱每一个人，我只是个游客。他问了我的宗教信仰。

"Are you Shia or Sunni? What kind of Muslim are you?"

"你是什叶派还是逊尼派？你是哪种穆斯林？"

"A bad one. I had three drinks two hours ago."

"不称职的那种。两小时前我刚喝了三杯。"

He made me sign the pledge — a formal prohibition against reporting, photography, and information gathering, with full legal consequences — and watched me actually read it, which seemed to make him more suspicious rather than less, because apparently the expected behavior when presented with a legal document at a desert checkpoint is to just sign it, and the fact that I was reading it suggested I was the kind of person who thought carefully about what he was agreeing to.

他让我签署了一份保证书——一份正式禁止报道、摄影和搜集信息的禁令，并附带完整的法律后果。他盯着我读完了全文，这似乎反而让他更加怀疑，因为在沙漠检查站面对法律文件时，预期的行为显然是直接签字，而我仔细阅读的行为表明，我是那种会深思熟虑自己所同意之内容的人。

Then he said he'd look through my bags and asked if there was anything constituting recording equipment. The gimbal I could explain away. The Ray-Bans are sunglasses. But the microphone kit — furry windscreen, professional recording setup — that would end the trip before it started.

接着他说要检查我的行李，并询问是否有任何属于录音录影设备的东西。云台我可以解释过去。雷朋眼镜只是太阳镜。但那个麦克风套装——带有防风毛罩的专业录音设备——一旦被发现，这段旅程还没开始就会宣告结束。

He opened the Pelican case. Cigars on top. I offered him one. He took it, nodded with what I interpreted as genuine appreciation, lifted one layer of sweatpants, and closed

the case.

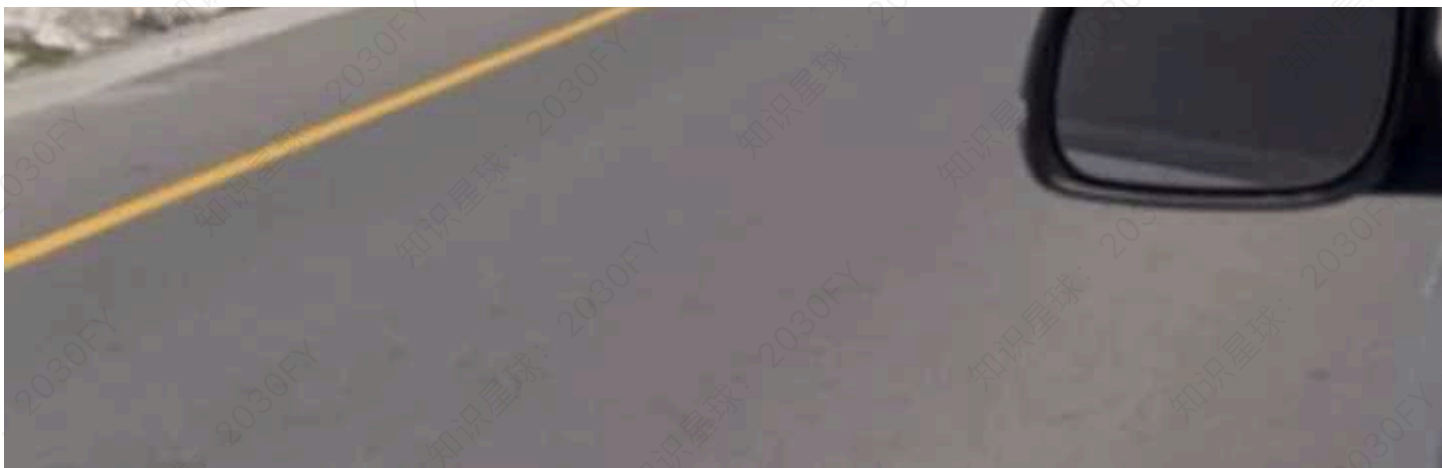
他打开了派力肯防护箱。雪茄放在最上面。我递给他一支。他接了过去，点了点头，我将其解读为真诚的感激，随后他拎起一层运动裤，合上了箱子。

IV. Ghost Town IV. 鬼城

Forty minutes past the border, the Omani coast opened into something genuinely beautiful — crystal water, mountains falling into the sea.

越过边境四十分钟后，阿曼海岸展现出一片真正壮丽的景色——清澈见底的海水，群山直插入海。





The first meeting I had in Oman reinforced the counterintuitive but persistent theme I repeatedly encountered: you can have hot war and commercial diplomacy happening at the same time. Before this trip, I was thinking about the situation in binary terms: either the strait is open or it's closed. Either the conflict is escalating or it's winding down. That's not how it works.

我在阿曼参加的第一场会面强化了一个反直觉但始终存在的观点，这也是我反复遇到的：热战与商业外交可以同时进行。在这次旅行之前，我一直以二元对立的思维看待局势：海峡要么开放，要么关闭；冲突要么升级，要么平息。但事实并非如此。

I managed to secure a meeting with an Omani official. A stoic, almost Yoda-like figure who had spent his entire life on the mouth of the Strait. He referred back to the Iran-

Iraq war, the Iraq-Kuwait war and the 1970s crisis.

我设法获得了一次与阿曼官员会面的机会。他是一位冷静、近乎尤达大师般的人物，一生都生活在海峡口。他回顾了伊朗-伊拉克战争、伊拉克-科威特战争以及 20 世纪 70 年代的危机。

“What you’ll see happening,” he told me, “is a huge uptick in traffic alongside continued ground conflict in Iran.”

“你会看到的情况是，”他告诉我，“在伊朗持续发生地面冲突的同时，交通流量也会大幅增加。”

“That sounds contradictory.” I replied. He acknowledged this.

“这听起来很矛盾，”我回答道。他对此表示认同。

“Yeah, we just adapt to what’s going on. And like, this might seem counterintuitive to you, but this is the way of the region.” The framing he gave me was simple enough: The ground operations may or may not continue. Everyone else is trying to get on with their lives. It was described to me like two of your friends are having a fight, and the

rest of you are still living your lives and going to bars. That's the story on the ground.

“是的，我们只是顺应局势。而且，这在你看来可能有些违背直觉，但这就是该地区的生存之道。”他给我的解释很简单：地面行动可能会继续，也可能不会。其他所有人都在努力过好自己的生活。他向我描述的情景就像是：你的两个朋友在打架，而你们其他人照样过日子、去酒吧。这就是当地的真实情况。

Afterwards, I arrived at my hotel. Normally a tourist destination, now looking like The Overlook from The Shining. I was one of two guests in a hundred rooms, the whole place being run at a loss to maintain the illusion that tourism was still happening.

随后，我到达了酒店。这里通常是旅游胜地，现在看起来却像《闪灵》里的远望酒店（The Overlook）。一百间客房里只有我这一两名住客，整个地方都在亏本经营，只为了维持旅游业仍在运作的假象。

The dolphin tour guy cancelled on me as soon as I tried to get back in touch, which, to be fair to him, was the rational response to the current security environment, and which was also, to be fair to me, extremely inconvenient. I walked the town for hours — talking to everyone, hotel staff and fishermen's families and anyone who might know someone with a boat — getting rejected by every operator, twelve grand in cash

in my pocket and no ride to the strait.

那个带海豚游览团的家伙一等我再次联系他就取消了预约。公平地说，面对当前的安全环境，这是理性的反应；但对我而言，这确实极其不便。我在镇上走了好几个小时——和所有人交谈，包括酒店员工、渔民家属，以及任何可能认识有船的人——结果被每一个经营者拒绝。我兜里揣着一万两千美元现金，却找不到去海峡的船。

I was the only Western person in the province, walking around in American clothes with cash in my pocket and wired headphones in, on the phone with Citrini while cars slowed down to look at me and kids pointed. The general atmosphere was that of a small town dealing with a moderately confusing alien visitation. It was the opposite of laying low and blending in.

我是整个省份唯一的西方面孔，穿着美式服装，兜里揣着现金，戴着有线耳机，正和 Citrini 通着电话。路过的车辆会减速打量我，孩子们对我指指点点。整体氛围就像是一个小镇在应对一场略显困惑的外星人造访。这与“保持低调并融入环境”完全背道而驰。

I ended up at a tiny canal off the heavily fortified main port, with speedboats along each side, where I met a group of Iranian smugglers who told me their entire career was running contraband to Iran: electronics, cigarettes, alcohol, every day. I asked if

they get arrested. Sometimes. One of their friends had died the week before.

我最终来到了戒备森严的主港口旁的一条小运河边，两岸停满了快艇。在那里，我遇到了一群伊朗走私犯，他们告诉我，他们的整个职业生涯就是每天向伊朗运送违禁品：电子产品、香烟、酒精。我问他们是否会被捕。他们说偶尔会，其中一个朋友就在前一周丧命了。

These guys were pro-IRGC and they were blunt about what they wanted: the strait open, under Iranian management. They wanted the business. They wanted the money. When I asked if the conflict had slowed their runs, they laughed.

这些家伙支持伊朗伊斯兰革命卫队（IRGC），而且对自己的诉求直言不讳：他们希望海峡开放，并由伊朗管理。他们想要这笔生意，他们想要钱。当我问及冲突是否减缓了他们的运输频率时，他们笑了起来。

They were in the Strait every day, there had been no decrease in illicit traffic — which, if you think about it, is its own kind of market signal. Just like the tankers leaving Kharg, if you're a ship aligned with the IRGC, you don't think twice about heading out to sea. It's a sign that Iran has the ability to be selective regarding which ships to hit.

他们每天都在海峡出没，非法运输从未减少——如果你仔细想想，这本身就是一种市场信号。就像从哈尔格岛驶出的油轮一样，如果你是一艘与伊朗伊斯兰革命卫队（IRGC）结盟的船只，你根本不会对出海有任何顾虑。这表明伊朗有能力有选择性地挑选打击对象。

Among this group of guys, there was only one Omani in the group. I went up to him and spoke Arabic. His name was Hamid, and after I pulled out a wad of cash, he said he'd have a speedboat ready by morning.

在这群人中，只有一个阿曼人。我走上前去用阿拉伯语和他交谈。他叫哈密德，在我掏出一叠现金后，他说他会在明早准备好一艘快艇。

V. "Fuck The Police" 五、“去他妈的警察”

That night I passed out around nine and was woken by the worst sound I've ever heard a telephone make — a low, droning, flatlining beep. The front desk informed me that two gentlemen from the CID were downstairs to ask me questions. CID, in the Gulf, is the CIA, with even less chill.

那天晚上我九点左右就昏睡过去，结果被我听过最难听的电话声吵醒了——那是一种低沉、单调、像心电图停跳般的鸣叫声。前台通知我，刑事调查局（CID）的两位先生在楼下要问我话。在海湾地区，CID 就相当于中央情报局（CIA），而且更加冷酷无情。

I chucked my iPhone in the room safe and grabbed the burner. They'd seen the Citrini tweets about Analyst #3 — thanks, James.

我把 iPhone 扔进房间保险箱，抓起备用机。他们已经看到了 Citrini 关于 3 号分析师的推文——多谢了，詹姆斯。

I went downstairs in my pajamas and hotel slippers. There's a piece of opsec you learn as an Arab English speaker: if things get sticky, you only speak English, because Arabic opens doors you don't want opened — the possibility that you're a spy, a sympathizer, any number of things that are very hard to shake once someone decides you might be them. So I came downstairs speaking English only. "Hello guys. How are you? I speak English." The hotel receptionist — the same man I'd been chatting with in Arabic all day — turned to the agents and said: "This guy speaks perfect Arabic."

我穿着睡衣和酒店拖鞋下了楼。作为一名会说英语的阿拉伯人，有一条你必须学会的行动安全准则：如果情况变得棘手，你只能说英语。因为阿拉伯语会开启一些你并不想打开的大门——比如你可能是间谍、同情者，或者任何一旦被人定性就很难摆脱的身份。所以我下楼时只说英语：“大家好，你们好吗？我说英语。”而那位整天都在和我用阿拉伯语聊天的酒店前台，转头对特工们说：“这家伙的阿拉伯语说得棒极了。”

They told me to come with them. I asked if I could change out of my pajamas. They said get in the car. It was pitch black outside — and, also, inside the Honda Accord with two agents in the front and a very large man in the back who was about to become my seatmate. For twenty minutes we drove through Khasab, a town with no streetlights carved into mountains, the kind of darkness where you can't see the road, and not one of these men said a single word. The only sounds were phone calls from a

superior: “Do you have him?” and “How far away are you?”

他们叫我跟他们走。我问能不能先换掉睡衣。他们说上车。外面漆黑一片——本田雅阁车内也是如此，前排坐着两名特工，后排坐着一个体型硕大的男人，他即将成为我的座上宾。我们在哈萨卜（Khasab）行驶了二十分钟，这是一座嵌在山间、没有路灯的小镇，那种黑暗让你根本看不清路面，而车里的男人一言不发。唯一的声响是上级打来的电话：“接到他了吗？”以及“你们还有多远？”

I broke the silence and asked if there was a problem. The guy in front turned to the agent who'd picked me up and said, “Answer him.” The agent said, “No problem,” and the car went quiet again. At the station: “We have him in custody.”

我打破沉默，询问是否出了什么问题。前排的人转向接我的那名特工说：“回答他。”特工说：“没问题，”车内再次陷入死寂。到达警察局后，他们汇报：“我们已将其拘留。”

They went through everything, leaving the room and coming back, letting me stew.

“We just find it hard to believe you're here for tourism.” They hinted I was working for another government, bluffed me about an Iraqi passport I don't have, took a written statement, and asked who I was with in Dubai. When I gave them a certain last name of someone I knew, the energy in the room shifted in a way that suggested this name meant something to them. I told them to call him and confirm that I was chill. They left me alone for hours in the kind of waterless room where you have a lot of time to

think about the series of decisions that brought you here.

他们搜查了一切，进进出出，让我独自焦虑。“我们只是觉得很难相信你是来旅游的。”他们暗示我在为另一个政府工作，拿一本我根本没有的伊拉克护照诈我，录了书面陈述，并询问我在迪拜和谁在一起。当我报出我认识的一个人的姓氏时，房间里的气氛发生了微妙的变化，似乎这个名字对他们来说意味着什么。我让他们打电话给那个人，确认我没有威胁。他们把我单独关在一个滴水未进的房间里好几个小时，在那样的环境下，你有充足的时间去反思是哪一系列决定让你落到了这步田地。

On the way out, having apparently decided I was more idiot than spy, they delivered the real blow: “*We know about your boat trip. Cancel it. You’re not going.*” They dropped me off back at my hotel with a parting comment, “*We hope to have you back as a tourist in less...sensitive times.*” A sincere, but eerie comment.

在离开的路上，他们显然认定我只是个白痴而非间谍，于是给了我致命一击：“我们知道你的乘船计划。取消它，你走不了。”他们把我送回酒店，临别时说了一句：“我们希望在不那么.....敏感的时期，欢迎你作为游客再次光临。”这句话听起来既真诚又令人毛骨悚然。

I messaged Citrini on Signal. The trip was dead. I got back the kind of message you send when you’re trying to be supportive from a comfortable distance: “Dude, it’s okay. It’s not meant to happen. It’s probably safer for you not to get on the strait, ship

numbers and conversations are fine.”

我在 Signal 上给 Citrini 发了消息。行程泡汤了。我收到了一条那种试图在舒适的安全距离外表达支持的消息：“哥们，没事的。这说明命中注定不该去。不上海峡对你来说可能更安全，有船舶数据和谈话记录就够了。”

I stared at that text for a long time. The intelligence service had told me explicitly to cancel. Hamid's number was compromised. The rational move — the move I would advise any other human being on earth to make — was to go to bed and drive back to Dubai in the morning as a person who had tried and failed and could live with that.

我盯着那条短信看了很久。情报部门已经明确告诉我要取消。哈米德的号码暴露了。理性的做法——也是我会建议地球上任何其他其他人去做的一步——就是上床睡觉，明早开车回迪拜，做一个尝试过但失败了、且能坦然接受这一切的人。

I messaged Hamid and told him what happened. The CID pulled up, took his number, took my shit. Then I wrote: “What if we just went anyways?”

我给哈米德发了消息，告诉他发生了什么。刑事调查局（CID）的车停了下来，记下了他的号码，查了我的东西。然后我写道：“如果我们还是照去不误呢？”

Hamid wrote back, in Arabic: “Fuck the police.”

哈米德用阿拉伯语回道：“去他妈的警察。”

VI. The Strait VI. 海峡

In the morning, Hamid's "speedboat" turned out to be a forty-year-old dinghy with a few-hundred-CC engine and no GPS — everything by feel, navigation by a lifetime of knowing these waters and a shitty radio half-lashed to the hull. As we headed out, two Iranian smugglers we'd seen loading up at port ripped past us toward Iran, and minutes later two Coast Guard ships appeared out of nowhere and detained them. While every officer in the area was occupied processing two boats full of contraband, we slid along the coast and through unnoticed. Hamid looked at me: "We're good."

第二天早上，哈米德（Hamid）所谓的“快艇”结果是一条有着四十年船龄的小破船，发动机只有几百毫升排量，而且没有 GPS——全凭感觉，靠着对这片海域一辈子的了解和一台半捆在船体上的破烂无线电导航。当我们出发时，两名我们在港口见过正在装货的伊朗走私者飞速掠过我们向伊朗驶去，几分钟后，两艘海岸警卫队的船只凭空出现并扣押了他们。当该地区所有的官员都忙于处理这两船违禁品时，我们沿着海岸线悄无声息地穿过，未被察觉。哈米德看着我：“我们安全了。”

In Kumzar — a village so remote it speaks its own hybrid of Portuguese, Farsi, and Arabic, where half the families have relatives in Bandar Abbas and people transit to Iran as casually as they transit within Oman — I ate bread on the ground with

fishermen who told me things that no tracking system and no satellite can show you.

在库姆扎尔 (Kumzar) ——一个偏远到拥有自己混合了葡萄牙语、波斯语和阿拉伯语的方言的小渔村, 那里一半的家庭在阿巴斯港 (Bandar Abbas) 都有亲戚, 人们往返伊朗就像在阿曼境内旅行一样随意——我坐在地上和渔民们一起吃着面包, 他们告诉我了一些任何追踪系统和卫星都无法显示的事情。

Tankers passing through four or five a day, completely dark on AIS. The volume, they said, is higher than what the data suggests, and it's been accelerating in the past couple days through the Qeshm channel.

每天有四五艘油轮经过, AIS (自动识别系统) 完全处于关闭状态。他们说, 实际运量比数据显示的要高, 而且过去几天通过格什姆海峡的流量一直在加速。

They told me about drone strikes on civilian vessels and fishing boats — things blowing up that aren't military targets and that never appear in any reporting anywhere. A man who'd been back and forth across the water twenty times since the conflict started put it like this: you see a vessel, you hear something, and it blows up. Just another day.

他们告诉我, 民用船只和渔船遭到了无人机袭击——那些并非军事目标的物体发生了爆炸, 但从未出现在任何地方的报道中。一个自冲突开始以来往返这片海域二十次的人这样描述: 你看到一艘船, 听到一声响, 然后它就炸了。不过是寻常的一天。

Old fishermen sitting on the beach told me both things at the same time — way more boats passing through than you think, and way more strikes happening than you think. I asked how these seemingly contradictory narratives could both be right. They didn't have a framework for it. They just shrugged. The neat binary — open or closed, escalating or de-escalating — simply doesn't match the observable reality from the shoreline of Kumzar. It's both more ships and more strikes. This was beginning to be a theme — US threats of total war while US allies negotiated with the target, drone strikes increasing at the same time that vessel traffic crossing the strait rose. Nothing seemed set in stone.

坐在海滩上的老渔民同时告诉了我两件事——经过的船只比你想象的多得多，发生的袭击也比你想象的多得多。我问这两个看似矛盾的说法怎么可能同时成立。他们没有一套理论框架来解释，只是耸了耸肩。那种非黑即白的二元论——开放或关闭、升级或降级——根本无法匹配在库姆扎尔海岸线观察到的现实。事实是船只更多了，袭击也更多了。这正逐渐成为一个主题：美国威胁要发动全面战争，而美国的盟友却在与目标进行谈判；无人机袭击在增加，与此同时穿过海峡的船只流量也在上升。似乎没有什么事是板上钉钉的。

What I was told — by the Kumzaris, by an Omani official I met the following day, corroborated by Iranians on the water — is that this is about Iran asserting that you need *approval* to transit, but the approval is kind of a propaganda tool. A way of portraying the US as the unreliable ally and Iran as the rational actor making the best

of a bad situation.

库姆扎里人、我次日见到的一位阿曼官员，以及水面上的伊朗人都告诉了我同样的信息：伊朗此举是为了声明过境需要获得批准，但这种批准更像是一种宣传工具。这是一种将美国描绘成不可靠的盟友，而将伊朗塑造为在恶劣局势中尽力而为的理性行为体的方式。

It is Iran saying: We can operate the Strait peacefully, we can enforce safety under our management, and the proof of our sovereignty is that commerce will continue to flow regardless of what the United States does. Follow our process, pass our diligence, and you're fine.

伊朗传达的信息是：我们可以和平地运营海峡，我们可以在我们的管理下执行安全保障，而我们主权的证明就是无论美国做什么，贸易都将继续流动。遵循我们的流程，通过我们的审查，你就没问题。

It also reminded me of something I had heard in Ras Al Khaimah. There, in a hotel bar, I met with an Aussie Greek vessel captain — a grizzled, bald guy who looked like Mike Ehrmantraut from *Breaking Bad*.

这也让我想起了在拉斯海马（Ras Al Khaimah）听到的一些传闻。在那里的一家酒店酒吧里，我遇到了一位希腊裔澳大利亚籍船长——一个头发花白、秃顶的家伙，长得酷似《绝命毒师》里的迈克·厄曼特劳特（Mike Ehrmantraut）。

We left the bar, walked out to the port and smoked cigarettes as he laid out the mechanics of the Iranian Toll Booth. His ship was in queue to receive Iranian approval to transit. They were in the process of submitting information. He described a queue of vessels lined up in this back-and-forth with Iranian intermediaries, waiting their turn. You don't go through if you don't get approved. This is the difference between a blockade and a toll road, and the market has been pricing the former while the reality on the water is setting up to look a lot more like the latter.

我们离开酒吧，走到港口，一边抽烟，一边听他讲解“伊朗收费站”的运作机制。他的船正在排队等待伊朗的过境批准。他们当时正在提交相关信息。他描述了一队船只与伊朗中间人的反复交涉中排队等待。如果不获得批准，你就无法通过。这就是“封锁”与“收费公路”的区别，而市场一直在对前者进行定价，但水面上的现实情况正变得越来越像后者。

He disabused me of more than a few ideas that, in hindsight, can only be described as situation-monitor-slop. He told me nobody really thought the strait was mined. His reaction to the idea of insurance being the only reason vessels weren't crossing was one of near incredulity, *"The bottleneck is not wanting to die. Insurance? Do you think we want to die?"* he asked. *"Look, some guys will run it. Dynacom, Sinokor, they've got balls. But think about it from the owner's side. You send your ship through, it gets hit, now what? You're out a vessel in the hottest rate environment any of us have ever seen. Insurance pays you out, great, but you can't buy a replacement tomorrow. The fleet's spoken for. Meanwhile the guy*

who kept his ship parked as floating storage in the Gulf is printing money doing nothing. So yeah, it's not just about dying. It's about being stupid."

他纠正了我不少想法，事后看来，那些想法只能被描述为“只会盯着监控屏幕意淫出来的废话”。他告诉我，根本没人真的认为海峡里布满了水雷。对于“保险是船只不愿过境的唯一原因”这一观点，他的反应近乎不可思议：“瓶颈在于不想死。保险？你觉得我们想死吗？”他问道。“听着，有些人会硬闯。希腊 Dynacom、韩国长锦商船

(Sinokor)，他们有种。但你从船东的角度想想。你派船过去，被击中了，然后呢？在大家见过的租金行情最火爆的时候，你损失了一艘船。保险公司赔钱给你，太棒了，但你明天买不到替代船只。现有的船队早就被订光了。与此同时，那个把船停在海湾里当浮动仓储的家伙，什么都不干就在印钱。所以，这不仅仅关乎生死，还关乎别犯傻。”

As I stood looking out on the waters of the port listening to him explain this all, I realized how many of the narratives that had been tossed across the desk or on IB chat were beginning to seem...well...pretty fucking stupid. These were real people out here, with real human motivations and real human emotions. That same framework applied to most of the decision-makers involved.

当我站在港口眺望水面，听着他解释这一切时，我意识到那些在办公桌前或 IB 聊天频道里传来传去的叙事，有多少开始显得.....嗯.....极其愚蠢。这里生活着真实的人，有着真实的人类动机和真实的人类情感。同样的框架也适用于大多数相关的决策者。

The Omanis — the most neutral observers in the Gulf, neighbors with Iran the longest — generally agreed with this characterization. Their view was that the Iranians were rational and predictable. The Kumzaris, whose families live in Bandar Abbas and whose army is the IRGC, had more extreme views. They told me this war would be their chance to humble the empire.

阿曼人——海湾地区最中立的观察者，也是伊朗最长久的邻居——普遍认同这一特征。他们的观点是，伊朗人是理性且可预测的。而那些家人住在阿巴斯港、军队即是革命卫队的库姆扎里人，则持有更极端的观点。他们告诉我，这场战争将是他们羞辱那个帝国的机会。

We left Kumzar and headed for open water.

我们离开库姆扎尔，驶向开阔海域。





When the Iranian coast came into full view, I lit a cigar. Twelve miles out, Qeshm Island was visible in the distance — the first island in Iran, which would be hit by airstrikes the following day, a fact I did not know at the time other than from my friends at the poker game who warned it could happen. The day after that, it would be the site of a U.S. F15, and later an A-10, being shot down.

当伊朗海岸线清晰地展现在眼前时，我点燃了一支雪茄。在 12 英里外，格什姆岛（Qeshm Island）隐约可见——那是伊朗领土的第一座岛屿，第二天它就遭到了空袭。当时我对此并不知情，除了在扑克牌局上听朋友们警告过可能会发生这种事。而在那之后的又一天，那里成为了一架美国 F-15、随后又有一架 A-10 战斗机被击落的地点。

Then I looked up, and the war became real in a way that no amount of satellite imagery or AIS data can prepare you for.

随后我抬起头，战争以一种卫星图像或 AIS 数据无法让你准备好的方式变得真实。

You can see the Shahed drones with your naked eyes: propellers spinning, cruising through the sky at low enough altitude that the silhouette is unmistakable. I raised my phone to take a picture and Hamid — the fuck-the-police guy — screamed at me not to. American drones were operating separately, higher up. AIS-off tankers were appearing on my phone's signal from the Omani SIM, ships that don't exist on any tracking platform, ghosts on the water that the Kumzaris had told me about and that I was now watching with my own eyes.

肉眼就能看到见证者（Shahed）无人机：螺旋桨旋转着，在足够低的高度掠过天空，轮廓清晰可辨。我举起手机想拍张照片，哈米德——那个“去他妈的警察”的家伙——冲我大喊不要拍。美国的无人机在更高处独立运行。我的手机通过阿曼 SIM 卡接收到了关闭 AIS 的油轮信号，这些船只在任何追踪平台上都不存在，是库姆扎里人（Kumzaris）曾向我提及、而我现在正亲眼目睹的水上幽灵。

And then I saw a Greek Dynacom ship ripping straight through the center of the strait — not hugging the margins like every other captain, not creeping along the coast, but charging through the middle as if this were peacetime. It was the only vessel doing that. Everyone else was hedging, minimizing their profile, trying to be small. This ship was not shy. It had clearly cut a deal, exactly the kind of bespoke arrangement the Kumzaris and the Omanis had described. If you want a single image that confirms the

thesis that the strait is reopening under Iranian management, it's a Greek tanker running full speed through the center of Hormuz while drones fly overhead and everyone else hides along the edges.

接着，我看到一艘希腊 Dynacom 公司的船只正从海峡中心破浪前行——它不像其他船长那样紧贴边缘航行，也不沿海岸线蠕动，而是像在和平时期一样从中间横冲直撞。它是唯一一艘这样做的船只。其他所有人都在观望，尽量保持低调，试图让自己显得渺小。这艘船却毫不避讳。它显然已经达成了某种协议，正是库姆扎里人（Kumzaris）和阿曼人所描述的那种定制化安排。如果你需要一个画面来证实“海峡正在伊朗管理下重新开放”这一论点，那就是一艘希腊油轮在无人机盘旋头顶、其他船只都躲在边缘航行时，全速穿过霍尔木兹海峡的中心。

We also observed what appeared to be Chinese vessels transiting the Qeshm-Larak Channel, and confirmed ships flagged from India, Malaysia, Japan (LNG tanker), Greece, France (container ship), Oman, and Turkey.

我们还观察到疑似中国船只通过格什姆-拉拉克通道（Qeshm-Larak Channel），并确认了悬挂印度、马来西亚、日本（液化天然气运输船）、希腊、法国（集装箱船）、阿曼和土耳其国旗的船只。

Communities along the strait had reported two to four ships a day through the channel roughly in the two weeks before our arrival. We confirmed 15 ships crossing the Strait on April 2nd. The counting methodology was not exactly institutional-grade (a

barstool with a sightline and a Chinese phone zoomed to maximum from the hotel, supplemented by a notebook on the water). But the data it produced was significant.

海峡沿岸的社区报告称，在我们抵达前的两周左右，每天大约有两到四艘船只通过该航道。而我们在4月2日确认了15艘船只穿越海峡。虽然计数方法并不算机构级（一个视野良好的吧台凳，一部变焦到最大的国产手机，辅以水面上的笔记本记录），但它产生的数据却意义重大。

Contacts told us that pace continued on the 4th, with another 15-18 ships crossing. That's the prior week's worth of traffic in two days.

知情人士告诉我们，这种节奏在4日仍在持续，又有15至18艘船只通过。这相当于在两天内完成了此前一周的交通量。

This all confirmed what the Aussie captain had told me — that the drones only hit tankers that refused to comply with Iran's rules of the road.

这一切都证实了那位澳洲船长告诉我的话——无人机只攻击那些拒绝遵守伊朗航行规则的油轮。

But out on the water, I remained vigilant. Hamid and the Kumzaris had told me about fishing boats getting obliterated for no discernible reason, random civilian vessels destroyed without warning or explanation, and likely accidents. These drones did not appear to be making fine distinctions between a noncompliant tanker and a forty-year-

old dinghy.

但在海面上，我依然保持警惕。哈米德和库姆扎里人曾告诉我，有些渔船莫名其妙地被炸得粉碎，随机的民用船只在毫无预警或解释的情况下被摧毁，还有一些很可能是意外。这些无人机似乎并不会在违规油轮和一艘有着四十年船龄的小艇之间做出细致的区分。

So I figured, if I was out here, I might as well go for it. I hopped in the water and swam. Cigar in my mouth. Shaheds above. Hamid took a picture with my Chinese burner phone.

所以我心想，既然已经到了这儿，不如就豁出去了。我跳进水里游了起来。嘴里叼着雪茄，头顶飞着见证者（Shahed）无人机。哈米德用我的国产备用机拍了张照片。

I hopped back onboard. Then the smuggling boats started running past — eight of them, maybe more, Iranian kids in their early twenties with big smiles, waving, throwing cigarettes across to us. I threw up a peace sign. And then one of them turned and pulled directly toward us at high speed from the direction of Iran. For five seconds I was certain it was over. The Emirati in the barrel — 72 pieces — was the only thing

in my head.

我跳回了船上。接着，走私船开始从旁疾驰而过——大约有八艘，甚至更多。船上二十出头的伊朗小伙子，带着灿烂的笑容，向我们挥手，还把香烟扔向我们。我比了个和平的手势。随后，其中一艘船突然转向，从伊朗方向全速朝我们冲来。有那么五秒钟，我确信一切都结束了。脑子里唯一的念头就是那个被装进桶里的阿联酋人——被切成了72块。

Turned out, it wasn't the IRGC. Just another smuggler. He slowed alongside our boat, close enough that I could see his face. He was smoking a cigarette. I was smoking a cigar. He held out his cigarette and I handed him my cigar, and we looked at each other across the gap between two boats in the middle of the most contested waterway on earth, and we nodded, and we smiled, and neither of us said a word.

结果发现，那不是伊朗革命卫队（IRGC），只是另一个走私犯。他在我们的船旁减速，近到我能看清他的脸。他正抽着烟，而我正抽着雪茄。他递出他的烟，我把雪茄递给了他。在这片地球上争议最激烈的水域中心，我们隔着两船之间的空隙对视，点头，微笑，谁也没有说一句话。

That's something I'll tell my grandkids about.

这件事我能跟孙辈们讲一辈子。

We decided it was time to leave.

我们决定是时候离开了。



VII. The Port Jail VII. 港口监狱

On the way back, riding the highest high of my life, reception flickering back on my phone, the Coast Guard intercepted us with rifles drawn. I went straight to English — “Tourist” — while they screamed at Hamid, and I was scrambling to send files to my other phone and delete pictures, because if they found a single photograph of a drone, I was gonna be in a bad spot — the kind the guys at my poker table couldn’t help me with.

在回程途中，我正处于人生中最亢奋的时刻，手机信号也开始闪烁恢复，这时海岸警卫队举着步枪拦截了我们。当他们对着哈米德大声咆哮时，我直接用英语喊道——“游客”——同时手忙脚乱地将文件传输到另一部手机并删除照片。因为如果他们发现哪怕一张无人机的照片，我就会陷入大麻烦——那种我牌桌上的哥们儿也帮不了我的大麻烦。

The officers escorted us to the place where they process smugglers — the port jail, not the police station, not the border, the facility for people whose lives the system doesn’t particularly value. They took the Chinese phone, said they’d go through everything on it, and threw me in one room and Hamid in another. Hamid’s boat had no GPS, just a handheld radio MacGyvered to the hull, and when the Coast Guard asked if we had navigation equipment and we said no, the officer delivered his assessment with the weary directness of a man who has seen a lot of stupid decisions and has ranked this

one near the top.

军官们把我们押解到了处理走私者的地方——那是港口监狱，不是警察局，也不是边境站，而是专门关押那些系统并不特别看重其性命的人的设施。他们收缴了那部中国产手机，声称要检查里面的所有内容，然后把我关进一个房间，把哈密德关进另一个房间。哈密德的船上没有 GPS，只有一个土法改装固定在船体上的手持无线电。当海岸警卫队询问我们是否有导航设备而我们回答没有时，那名军官给出了他的评价。他的语气中透着一种疲惫的直白，显然他见过太多愚蠢的决定，而这一次在他心目中名列前茅。

After a while — and after a high up friend apparently made some calls whose content I will probably never know — they let me go. They told me I was a moron, they were keeping the phone, and if they found anything incriminating I'd be prosecuted.

过了一会儿——在一位高层朋友显然打了一些我可能永远无从得知内容的电话之后——他们放我走了。他们骂我是个白痴，没收了我的手机，并警告说如果发现任何犯罪证据，我将会被起诉。

I never heard back from them. That was the nadir of the whole trip — the moment where I was closest to real, life-altering consequences. But I didn't care. I would have gone to jail. I was so high on the fact that I'd actually been on the strait — that I'd done the thing, seen it with my own eyes, gathered information that nobody else had — that I felt nothing resembling fear. I went back to the empty hotel bar and drank

eleven beers.

我再也没有收到他们的消息。那是整趟旅程的最低谷——也是我离真正足以改变人生的严重后果最近的一刻。但我并不在乎。就算去坐牢我也认了。我沉浸在一种极度的亢奋中：我真的去了海峡，我做到了，我亲眼见证了一切，收集到了无人知晓的信息——以至于我完全感觉不到恐惧。我回到空无一人的酒店酒吧，喝了十一瓶啤酒。

VIII. Getting Out VIII. 撤离

For the rest of my time in Oman I was under surveillance — three guys following me everywhere, the same faces at every turn, a car tailing me with the subtlety of a car that is not trying to be subtle. The staff was aggressively trying to get me to check out. It felt kind of fair. I hired a black SUV for a thousand dollars to take me around for the last few hours — should have been throwing money around from the start, because at these price points people will tell you anything and take you anywhere. Got fried chicken at a place called Hormuz Fried Chicken. It was gas.

在阿曼剩下的时间里，我一直处于监视之下——三个人如影随形，无论走到哪儿都能看到那几张熟面孔，一辆车尾随其后，其张扬程度完全没打算掩饰。酒店工作人员也表现得咄咄逼人，一心想让我退房。这倒也算公平。最后几个小时，我花一千美元雇了一辆黑色 SUV 带我四处转转——早该从一开始就这么大把撒钱的，因为在这个价位上，人们什么都会告诉你，也愿意带你去任何地方。我在一家叫“霍尔木兹炸鸡”的地方吃了炸鸡。味道绝了。





At the border on the way out, the guard's first words when he saw me: "He's here."

在出境处的边境，卫兵见到我时说的第一句话是：“他来了。”

They searched my bag. One of them picked up the Ray-Bans. "What is this?"

"Sunglasses." He put them down. The microphone kit was under my pants in the back.

He moved the clothes, didn't comment on any of the other contents.

他们搜查了我的包。其中一人拿起雷朋眼镜问：“这是什么？”“太阳镜。”他把眼镜放下了。麦克风套件藏在包后部我的裤子下面。他翻动了衣物，没有对其他任何物品发表评论。

“I guess it was someone else.”

“我想是别人吧。”

What We Learned and What It Means 我们的所见所闻及其意义

That's the story. What follows is different. We spent eight hours debriefing #3 after he got back, cross-referencing what he saw and heard against everything we knew from our own sources, public data and the conversations we'd had with informed parties in the region. The narrative above is told from #3's point of view because that's the most honest way to present field reporting. The analysis below is told from ours.

这就是故事的全部。接下来的内容则有所不同。在 3 号成员返回后，我们花了八个小时听取他的汇报，将他的所见所闻与我们从自有渠道、公开数据以及与该地区知情人士交流中所掌握的一切信息进行交叉比对。上文的叙述是以 3 号成员的视角展开的，因为这是呈现现场报告最真实的方式。而下文的分析则代表我们的观点。

The most important takeaway -- and our recommendation to readers -- is to drop biases and binary frameworks. What's happening is far more complex.

最重要的收获——也是我们对读者的建议——是摒弃偏见和二元对立的思维框架。正在发生的事情远比这复杂得多。

When we set off, we were under the assumption that the conflict would escalate and the Strait would remain closed off. This trip changed our mind on the latter, but not the former - a view we'd have thought was logically inconsistent before this assignment.

出发时，我们曾假设冲突会升级，且霍尔木兹海峡将保持封锁状态。这次行程改变了我们对后者的看法，但并未改变对前者的判断——在执行这次任务之前，我们会认为这种观点在逻辑上是不自洽的。

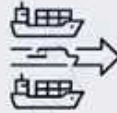
We also gained a more nuanced understanding of how things could proceed - our base case is less about closed/open and more about the messy outcome where the conflict continues at the same time that traffic through the strait rises. We view this as a symptom of the increasingly multipolar world we now live in, one where US allies are actively negotiating with Iran despite the US being engaged in an active conflict with them.

我们也对事态可能的进展有了更细致的理解——我们的基准预测不再是简单的“关闭”或“开放”，而是一种更复杂的局面：冲突持续的同时，通过海峡的交通流量反而有所增加。我们认为这是当今世界日益多极化的一个征兆，即尽管美国正与伊朗处于活跃冲突中，但美国的盟友们却在积极地与伊朗进行谈判。

Higher Conviction Views

Traffic Through the Strait Will Increase:

Regardless of scenario, we see traffic increasing gradually. We saw one Greek Dynacom ship go straight down the middle of the strait, indicating that even if it is mined it is not done so in an indiscriminate, absolute traffic-blocking manner.



The Diplomatic Tollbooth:

One of the more surprising aspects was how orderly things were. Iran has set up a checkpoint in the Strait of Hormuz, a checkpoint in the Strait of Hormuz, routed all approved traffic through a channel between Qeshm and Larak islands, and is collecting payment for passage.



The Escalation Contradiction:

We heard credible evidence of US staging for more ground operations, yet we believe this can occur even as volumes through the strait increase.



Realignment, Not Victory:

There are not two sides to this story — there are myriad. The winners will not be determined solely through military successes, but rather through the realigned, multipolar world.



CitriniResearch

And as for the mood on the ground? In the face of huge uncertainty and global attention was human resilience. There has been war here before -- there will be again. The US is interested, as always, in oil. The neighbors are fighting, the risk is real, but life goes on. This too shall pass.

至于当地的氛围？在巨大的不确定性和全球关注面前，展现出的是人类的韧性。这里以前发生过战争——以后也还会发生。美国一如既往地石油感兴趣。邻国在交战，风险是真实的，但生活仍在继续。这一切终将过去。

Our Core Thesis: Parallel War and Diplomacy

我们的核心论点：平行的战争与外交

The most counterintuitive finding from this trip is that hot war and commercial diplomacy are happening at the same time. The rest of the world is adapting and negotiating passage while the US continues with military action. US allies, including France, Greece, and Japan, are all figuring it out.

这次行程中最违背直觉的发现是，激烈的战争与商业外交正在同时进行。当美国继续采取军事行动时，世界其他国家正在适应并协商通行事宜。包括法国、希腊和日本在内的美国盟友，都在各自寻找解决之道。

Before, it would have been unlikely to imagine a world where Japan, the EU and other US allies were negotiating with a country the US is directly in conflict with to secure passage while the US maintained footing for an escalation of kinetic warfare. Now, that's simply how the world works. These countries must deal with the issues imposed, as the US won't be sorting it out on their behalf. This is what Trump told them to do in his address when he said nations that rely on the strait should "take care of that

passage” themselves.

过去，很难想象会出现这样一种局面：在日本、欧盟及其他美国盟友为了确保通行安全，正与一个同美国处于直接冲突的国家进行谈判，而美国则在为爆发直接军事冲突做准备。如今，这已成为世界的运作常态。这些国家必须自行处理面临的问题，因为美国不会代为解决。这正是特朗普在演讲中所传达的信息，他当时表示，依赖该海峡的国家应当自行“负责那条航道的安全”。

This is also what makes us feel that it is distinctly likely that we see both an escalation of the conflict within the next week or so while traffic simultaneously increases through the strait. The strait is not exclusively open or closed as a function of whether the conflict is escalating or de-escalating.

这也正是让我们觉得极有可能发生的情况：在未来一周左右的时间里，冲突既会升级，同时通过海峡的交通流量也会增加。海峡的开放或关闭，并不完全取决于冲突是在升级还是在降温。

The Qeshm Island port strikes are the clearest illustration of this. The strikes temporarily slowed movement. During the bombing itself, ships weren't really moving. But there were passages that same day.

格什姆岛港口遭袭就是最明显的例证。袭击导致运输暂时放缓。在轰炸进行期间，船只基本处于停滞状态。但在同一天内，航道便恢复了通行。



Satellite Imagery of Qeshm Island following the Airstrikes

空袭后格什姆岛的卫星图像

A ship crosses through the Qeshm-Larak Channel shortly after the Qeshm Airstrikes (Picture taken by Analyst #3 on the phone they let him keep)

一艘船只在格什姆岛空袭后不久穿过格什姆-拉拉克海峡（照片由分析师#3 用他们允许其保留的手机拍摄）



The strikes don't affect the long-term plan. You could blow the shit out of Qeshm Island and things would slow down, but it wouldn't change the fundamental trajectory.

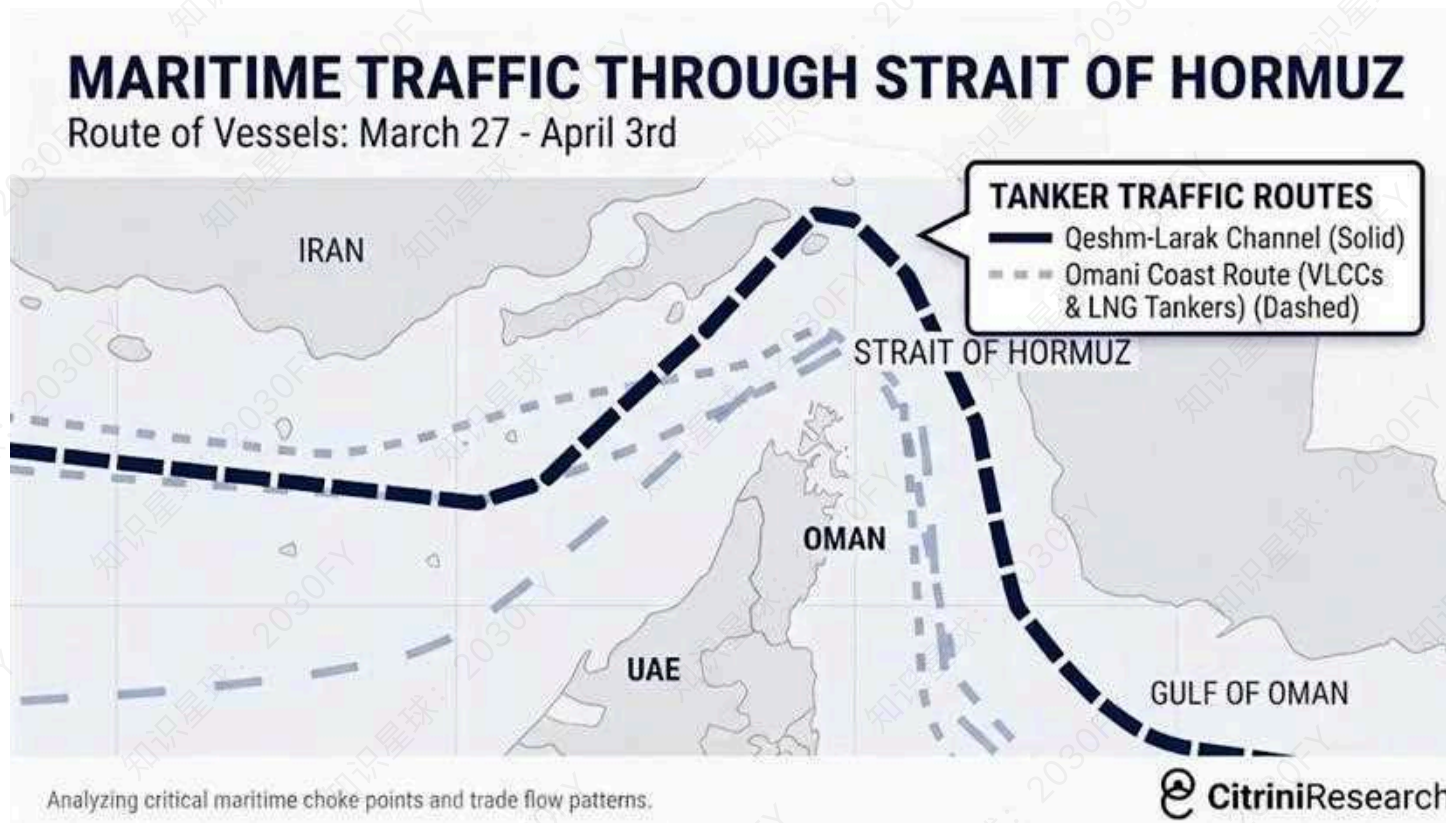
这些打击不会影响长期计划。就算你把格什姆岛炸个稀巴烂，进程也只是会放缓，但并不会改变根本的走向。

Two days after #3 was on the water, a US F-15 and A-10 were shot down over Qeshm. The A-10 crashed into the Persian Gulf. Ships passed through regardless that day, as well.

在 #3 出海两天后，一架美军 F-15 和一架 A-10 在格什姆岛上空被击落。那架 A-10 坠入了波斯湾。尽管如此，当天的船只依然照常通行。

On April 2nd, at least 15 ships crossed. The day after, more. Not a ton more, but more. People in communities along the strait told us that roughly two weeks before our arrival, the Qeshm-Larak channel was seeing maybe 2 to 5 ships per day. This still pales in comparison to the >100 per day that were crossing before the conflict, but we expect that this is how it will proceed. It will be messy, strait traffic volumes will pick up at the same time that the conflict proceeds.

4 月 2 日，至少有 15 艘船只通过。次日，数量更多。虽然增幅不算巨大，但确实在增加。海峡沿岸社区的居民告诉我们，在我们到达的大约两周前，格什姆-拉拉克（Qeshm-Larak）航道每天可能只有 2 到 5 艘船通过。尽管这与冲突前每天超过 100 艘的通行量相比仍显得微不足道，但我们预计情况将如此发展。过程会很混乱，海峡的交通量将在冲突持续的同时逐步回升。



Still, not many VLCCs have passed. In fact, not many vessels larger than Aframax at all have passed. If we keep seeing just LPG carriers and Handy-size tankers transiting, that doesn't change much. We would still be on a collision course for the global economy. The quickest way to avert that is for the US to allow Iran to run the strait...at

least, for now.

尽管如此，通过的超大型油轮（VLCC）并不多。事实上，几乎没有比阿芙拉型（Aframax）更大的船只通过。如果我们看到的只是液化石油气（LPG）运输船和便利型（Handy-size）油轮在通行，情况并不会有太大改观。全球经济仍将处于碰撞的航线上。避免这一局面的最快方法，就是美国允许伊朗掌控海峡.....至少目前如此。

Ships confirmed to be crossing included vessels from India, Malaysia, Japan, Greece, France, Oman, Turkey and China. Chinese vessels were spotted with AIS off, transiting through the Larak-Qeshm channel. We also witnessed what appeared to be the first crossings outside the Qeshm-Larak channel entirely: VLCCs and LNG tankers (empty) hugging the coast of Oman, transiting independently of the Iranian checkpoint.

确认通过的船只包括来自印度、马来西亚、日本、希腊、法国、阿曼、土耳其和中国的船只。中国船只被发现关闭了自动识别系统（AIS），正穿行于拉拉克-格什姆（Larak-Qeshm）航道。我们还目睹了似乎是首次完全在格什姆-拉拉克航道之外进行的航行：超大型油轮（VLCC）和液化天然气（LNG）运输船（空载）紧贴阿曼海岸行驶，独立于伊朗检查站进行过境。

The Greek Dynacom ship we saw went straight through the middle of the strait, the only vessel we saw do that. We have no idea how they pulled it off. George Procopiou, who runs Dynacom, has a history of running dark transits. This confirmed to us, at

least, that the Strait of Hormuz is not currently mined in a way that the “booby trap preventing all passage” narrative would suggest, and is consistent with the view of getting the strait back in action. Whether there are deep sea mines that can be activated selectively we, obviously, cannot say.

我们看到的这艘希腊 Dynacom 公司的船直接从海峡中心穿过，它是我们见过的唯一一艘这样做的船。我们完全不知道他们是如何做到的。经营 Dynacom 的 George Procopiou 曾有过进行隐秘航行的历史。这至少向我们证实了，霍尔木兹海峡目前并未像“阻止所有通行的陷阱”这种说法所暗示的那样布满水雷，这也与让海峡恢复运作的观点相一致。至于是否存在可以有选择性启动的深海水雷，显而易见，我们无法断言。

Iranian smugglers near Larak, whose whole lives consist of running contraband back and forth through the strait, told us they have seen a sharp increase in ships passing recently. Their impression was that nothing random is happening. Rather, all the ships passing through are talking to the IRGC and getting permission. Their expectation, relayed from family connected to the military, is that everything will go back to normal soon.

拉拉克岛附近的伊朗走私者们终其一生都在海峡两岸往返运送违禁品，他们告诉我们，最近观察到过往船只数量急剧增加。在他们的印象中，发生的这一切并非偶然。相反，所有通过海峡的船只都在与伊朗伊斯兰革命卫队（IRGC）沟通并获得许可。根据他们从有军方背景的家庭那里传达的预期，一切很快就会恢复正常。

Could a US ground operation grind this trend back down to a halt? Sure. But a fighter jet getting shot down almost directly above the queue didn't. Airstrikes on the Qeshm port didn't. The operation would need to be immense and almost specifically focused on shutting down this traffic, which doesn't seem to be in anyone's best interest.

The Iranian Toll Booth: How It Works

One of the more surprising aspects was how orderly things were. Iran has set up a functional checkpoint in the Strait of Hormuz, routed all approved traffic through a channel between Qeshm and Larak islands (with some exceptions along the coast of Oman and the one Greek ship we saw cross through the middle of the Strait), and is collecting payment for passage. No vessel has used the traditional shipping lanes since mid-March.

The mechanics work like this: A ship or its country contacts a middleman broker and submits information -- ownership structure, flag, cargo, crew composition, destination. A payment is made: cash, crypto, or (far more commonly than reported) a diplomatic workaround like the unfreezing of Iranian assets held in foreign bank accounts that gets past fears of sanctions.





A tanker waiting to cross through the channel

The toll system is enforced through drone and satellite imagery, and ships are approved via stations on Larak island. Enforcement is selective. There's a real diligence process where the Iranians check whether the vessel is secretly US-aligned. They're looking at ownership structures and shareholder bases, speaking with the crew. This means it's not going to be as simple as "X country got approved so we will just fly the flag of X country on our ship". Iran will be making a concerted effort to ensure the motivation to cut a deal with them is there and that workarounds are minimal.

Once approved, the vessel is granted passage with some form of confirmation. We heard references to a code or password-like system. This applies to both dark transits

(AIS off) and AIS-on transits. Nearly all traffic is being routed through Iranian territorial waters, rather than the traditional shipping lanes in Omani waters. If you pass, you get a confirmation code and you're escorted through. If you don't pass, you sit.

Perhaps the most important thing, however, is that vessels simply exiting the strait is not enough to have meaningful impact. Vessels must also return to reload cargos. That's what avoids a crisis here: vessels that are on the friendly or neutral list coming back to reload and keeping the flow of commodities through the strait running with business running seamlessly.

The Payment Myth. The consensus in Western media has been that these tolls are paid in Chinese yuan or cryptocurrency, and that's partially true. But what #3 learned from multiple sources on the ground is that the diplomatic channel is the dominant mechanism for non-Chinese vessels to get through – circumventing sanction fears -- and it's significantly underreported. Most of those payments are settled through a specific bank (Bank of Kunlun). The yuan story is real to a small degree but it's something of a front; those Chinese vessels will likely be able to pass without paying at all. Fear of OFAC sanctions are forcing other countries to find creative ways to pay - they're not necessarily paying in CNH. India secured passage through a diplomatic arrangement. France appears to have done the same, consistent with Macron's positioning against the US at the Security Council.

Insurance vs. Getting Blown Up. A popular narrative regarding crossing the strait has been that the only thing holding back ships from crossing is insurance. To put it directly, that's not the case. The primary concern is getting blown up. A secondary, lesser concern is paying Iran to cross and then getting popped on violating OFAC sanctions. That's why, right now, there's a real shot of an off-ramp where Trump demands that Iran opens the strait, Iran works with Oman to implement a toll and ships feel safe enough with the IRGC's guarantee to cross.

If the US, at this point, demanded a full opening without the toll and, at the same time, launched an operation with the intent of preventing Iran from running a toll, the traffic would grind to a halt. And if that operation took longer than 3-4 weeks, we'd be looking down the barrel of a catastrophe. Right now, the net hit to global commercial oil stocks is estimated at 10.6 million barrels per day. Habshan-Fujairah has been forced offline twice, and even accounting for pipeline redirections, remaining Hormuz flows, SPR releases, imports of sanctioned oil and builds in mideast oil stocks, it is still generous to estimate that if the Strait is still only transited by 15 ships a day by the end

of April the situation will be disastrous. *Everyone involved knows this.*

如果美国在此时要求完全开放海峡且不收“过路费”，并同时发起旨在阻止伊朗收取费用的行动，那么航运交通将会陷入停滞。如果该行动持续超过 3-4 周，我们将面临一场灾难。目前，全球商业石油库存的净损失估计为每日 1060 万桶。哈布山-富查伊拉

（Habshan-Fujairah）管道已两度被迫关停，即便考虑到管道改道、霍尔木兹海峡剩余流量、战略石油储备（SPR）释放、制裁油进口以及中东石油库存的增加，如果到 4 月底每天通过海峡的船只仍仅有 15 艘，情况也将是灾难性的。所有相关方都深知这一点。

We believe that this is the situation that is most tenable – US escorts are less of a reassurance than IRGC permission right now. No ships with IRGC permission have been struck. Whether the US allows Iran to exert this toll on the strait indefinitely is another matter entirely, but we feel in the interim it is likely that no direct action is taken to prohibit it. As long as the toll allows for some degree of passage out, it buys enough time for a solution that solves for two-way flow to be reached before an economic disaster takes place.

我们认为这是目前最稳固的局面——相比美国的护航，伊朗革命卫队（IRGC）的许可在当下更具保障作用。凡是获得 IRGC 许可的船只均未遭到袭击。至于美国是否会允许伊朗无限期地在海峡收取这种“过路费”则完全是另一回事，但我们认为在过渡期内，美方不太可能采取直接行动来禁止这种行为。只要这种收费模式还能维持一定程度的通航，就能为在经济灾难发生前达成双向通航的解决方案争取到足够的时间。

Iran's Intentions and the Wager

Every conversation Analyst #3 had in the region converged on one point: **Iran does not want the strait closed.**

All non-US countries view a non-functional strait as a catastrophe and Iran wants things to return to normal as fast as possible, provided it occurs in a way that asserts Iranian sovereignty. The best propaganda for Iran is a functioning strait where they look like the reasonable stewards of global trade, while the US looks like the disruptive force. If you look at the public messaging from Iranian officials, they're all trying to paint the US empire as a low-IQ malfunctioning thing, while positioning themselves as stewards for the world. The overarching goal from the Iranian side appears to be isolating the American empire and demonstrating that they can work with the rest of the world without the US. Shutting off the strait entirely again is akin to detonating a nuclear bomb in a war against another nuclear power – it's an absolute last resort.

The Omani official we met compared Iran's long-term vision for Hormuz to Turkey's management of the Bosphorus and Dardanelles under the Montreux Convention. That framework has governed the Turkish Straits since 1936 with Turkey holding full sovereignty over the waterway and Commercial vessels passing freely. Warships are subject to restrictions, notifications and tonnage limits that Turkey enforces at its

discretion. In wartime, Turkey can close the straits entirely to belligerent navies. The US, notably, is not a signatory. The arrangement has held for nearly ninety years, widely regarded as one of the more durable examples of rules-based order governing a strategic chokepoint.

Iran views what it's building now as the seed of something similar. Not a permanent blockade, but a sovereignty regime where Tehran controls the terms of passage, collects a toll, restricts hostile military vessels and permits commercial traffic under its own rules.

This is an important framing for investors because it tells you what the endgame looks like if the conflict doesn't end in total Iranian defeat. If the precedent Iran is reaching for is a framework that NATO member Turkey has operated successfully within for the better part of a century, do we have to start considering what that world looks like? Whether the US would ever accept that comparison is another question. In the short term, though, the options are a closed strait that will cause an economic catastrophe in the next 2-3 weeks, or this. But the fact that Iran is framing it this way tells you a lot about their confidence level and their intended audience: not Washington, but everyone else.

While we didn't speak with any Iranian decision makers, obviously, we did speak with Omani officials who have firsthand knowledge as to their view. It's easy enough to

know how the US views this conflict, but it seems valuable to know how the other side is performing calculus on it.

Iran is viewing this as a wager with decent odds. In two out of three scenarios, they come out better off. Of course, in the third one, Iran doesn't exist anymore.



All of the paths lead to ships flowing through the strait, though. The question is under whose flag they're sailing and who's collecting the toll, if any.

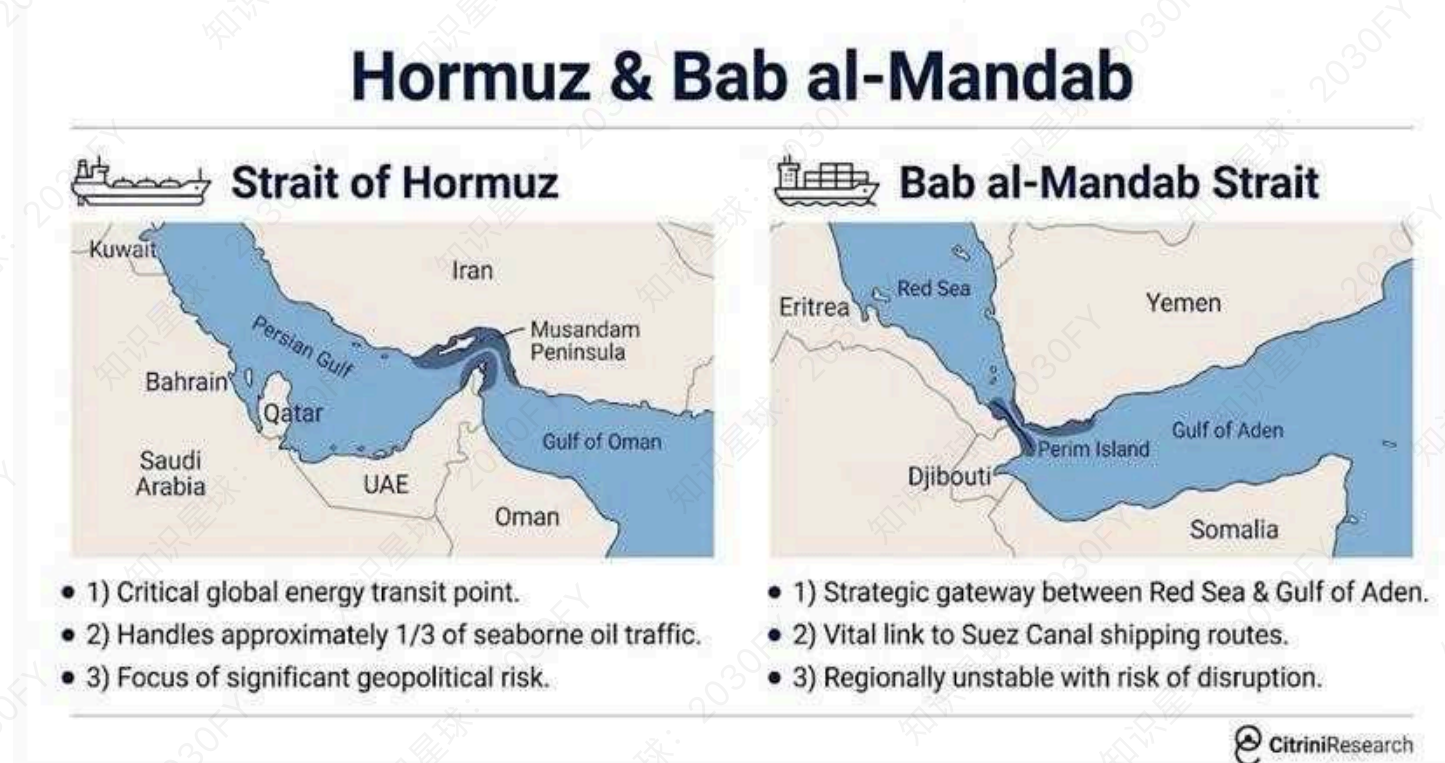
Centralized Iranian Command and The Houthi Card

The impression we got from our conversations with both the Omani official and villagers with close familial ties to the Iranian military was that, despite the significant losses they've taken, Iranian leadership is still centrally organized. There are no loose cannons at the top. The operations do not lack central coordination. This was consistent across every source.

The Omani official also made the point that Iran's behavior during the conflict — “lashing out, but with restraint” — is not the hallmark of a scattered or fractured regime. The proof: no ship that received IRGC clearance to transit has been hit. And the Houthis — the dog that hasn't barked — are being actively restrained. If Iran had lost operational control of its proxies, the Houthis would be the first to demonstrate it. They haven't. The targets they could hit but haven't are as informative as the ones they have. Restraint requires hierarchy, and hierarchy means the toll booth has a single operator.

Iran and Oman are working together to manage and police the strait. The Omanis view the strait as a shared responsibility. There were Iranian officials in Oman at the

time of our visit, discussing management protocols, although we did not attempt to speak with them for obvious reasons.



One of the most interesting pieces of intelligence from the trip: **the Houthis are being actively restrained by Iran.** This was told to us by a source in the Omani government and independently corroborated by our sources in military and government positions in the region.

The Houthis are historically first in any fight. Look at their track record against the UAE and Saudi Arabia. They're Iran's most aggressive proxy, and yet compared to Hezbollah, which is extremely active, the Houthis have been conspicuously quiet on Red Sea shipping. They've resumed launching missiles at Israel. They have not attempted to close the Bab al-Mandab.

That's deliberate. Iran is holding the Bab al-Mandab card in reserve, deploying it only if the conflict escalates to the point where Tehran needs maximum economic pressure. The Iranians are playing a hierarchy game. The fact that it hasn't been played yet is itself a signal of how calculated Iran's escalation ladder is. They're negotiating for sovereignty by letting ships through Hormuz and not holding the entire world hostage by directing the Houthis to seal off the Red Sea.

If that changes, we'll know the off-ramps have closed.

Throughout this conflict, the Iranians have shown a decent level of restraint. The Hormuz situation only started after a first war ended, a new war started, and their own internal red lines were crossed. That said, given where the US war path is heading, this level of Houthi escalation is possible.

Future Expectations:

What you'll see happening, and this was told to us directly by a source in the Omani Governor's office, is an uptick in traffic alongside continued ground conflict in Iran. Everyone stuck here isn't trying to stay stuck, they are trying to keep moving. The ground operations may or may not continue. Everyone else is trying to get on with their lives.

The consensus from everyone we spoke to was this: American and American-aligned vessels are going to have a hard time crossing for the duration of the conflict. But everyone else is queuing up for approval.

The list of approved nations is expanding fast. On March 26, Iran granted passage to five countries: China, Russia, India, Iraq, and Pakistan. Within a week, Malaysia, Thailand, the Philippines, France, and Japan had all secured access. We expect this list to keep growing as the rest of the world decides that guaranteeing its own energy supply is worth the diplomatic cost of dealing with Tehran.

We would be very surprised to see another EU ship struck over the rest of the conflict unless something drastically changes.

Our confidence in the strait gradually reopening is as high as it can be without certainty. It was the overwhelming conclusion driven by every experience and conversation on this trip. **The range of outcomes reduces to this: either the US sends Iran to the stone age, in which case they lose all capacity to enforce sovereignty and**

the strait reverts to open passage under American security. Or the conflict drags on, becomes expensive and unpopular, and Iran gets some version of what it wants — the strait reopening under Iranian management.

Meanwhile, the path of least resistance for every country that isn't America is to cut a deal with Iran and keep moving.

The Trades of Hormuz

Don't worry - we haven't forgotten why we exist. Exciting stories from Analyst #3 aside, we are, first and foremost, investment research analysts. The entire purpose of our voyage has been to give us better information to invest upon.

In our January **Macro Memo**, we began paying attention to the geopolitical tensions that had been rising since the Fordow operation. We did the same thing that we are attempting to do now – find trades that don't necessarily have to rely on a specific conflict outcome in order to have upside. We settled on a basket of oil and product tankers, heavily overweighting the ETF tracking tanker rate futures – **Breakwave Tanker Shipping (BWET US)**.

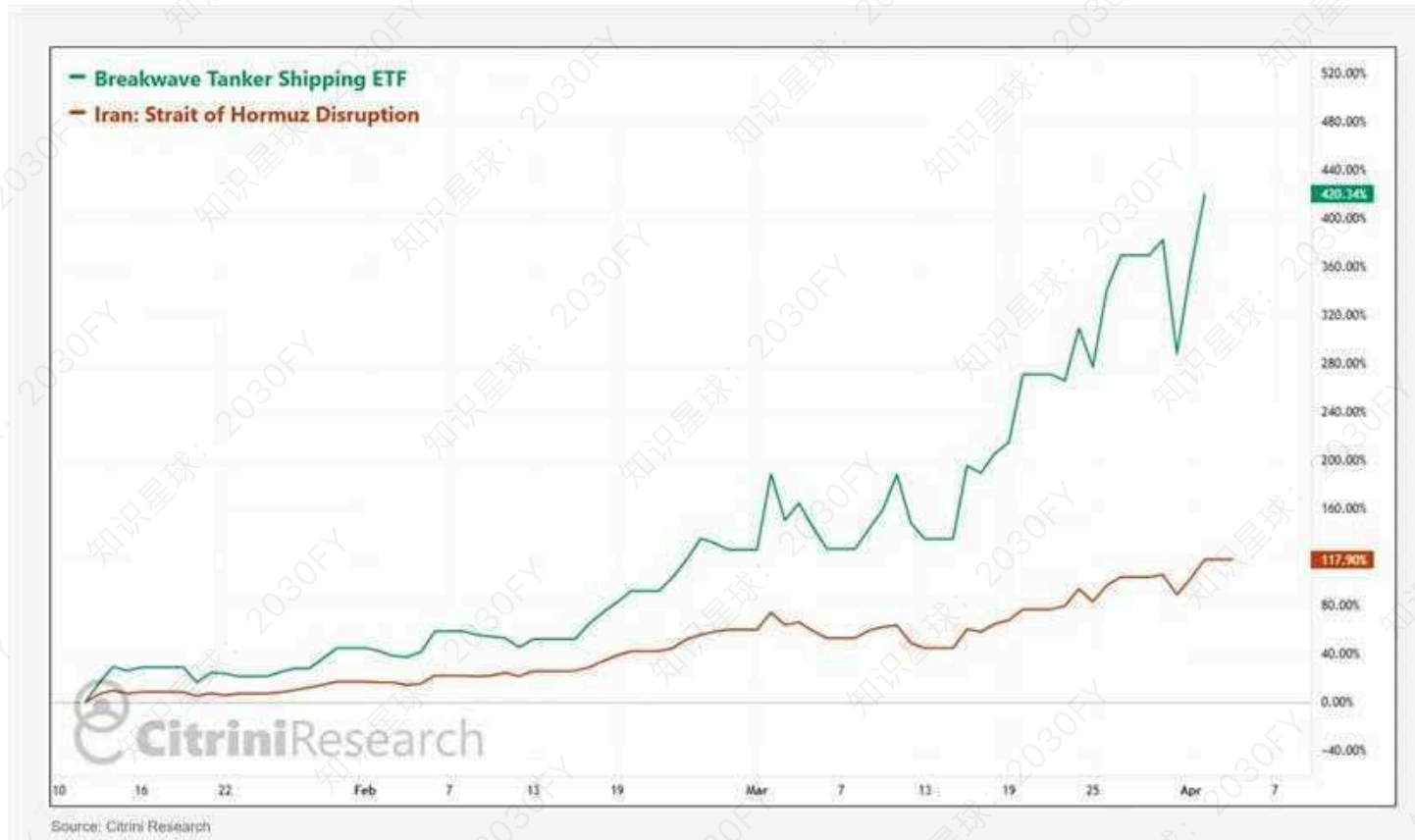
“There's a more interesting trade (with more non-Iran tailwinds) in the tankers. The structural setup here is more compelling than a simple geopolitical punt. There are a

confluence of factors: record levels of Iranian crude sitting on tankers, an aging global fleet, tightening Western sanctions on shadow shipping, and a VLCC market already trading at multi-year highs.”

Macro Memo: January 2026		
Geopolitical Tailwinds: Tanker Basket		
Name	Ticker	Weight
BREAKWAVE TANKER SHIPPING	BWET US Equity	20.0000%
FRONTLINE PLC	FRO NO Equity	15.0000%
DHT HOLDINGS INC	DHT US Equity	15.0000%
OKEANIS ECO TANKERS CORP	ECO US Equity	12.5000%
SCORPIO TANKERS INC	STNG US Equity	10.0000%
TORM PLC-A	TRMD US Equity	8.0000%
TEEKAY TANKERS LTD-CLASS A	TNK US Equity	6.5000%
INTERNATIONAL SEAWAYS INC	INSW US Equity	5.0000%
TSAKOS ENERGY NAVIGATION LTD	TEN US Equity	4.0000%
NORDIC AMERICAN TANKERS LTD	NAT US Equity	4.0000%

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This performed well.



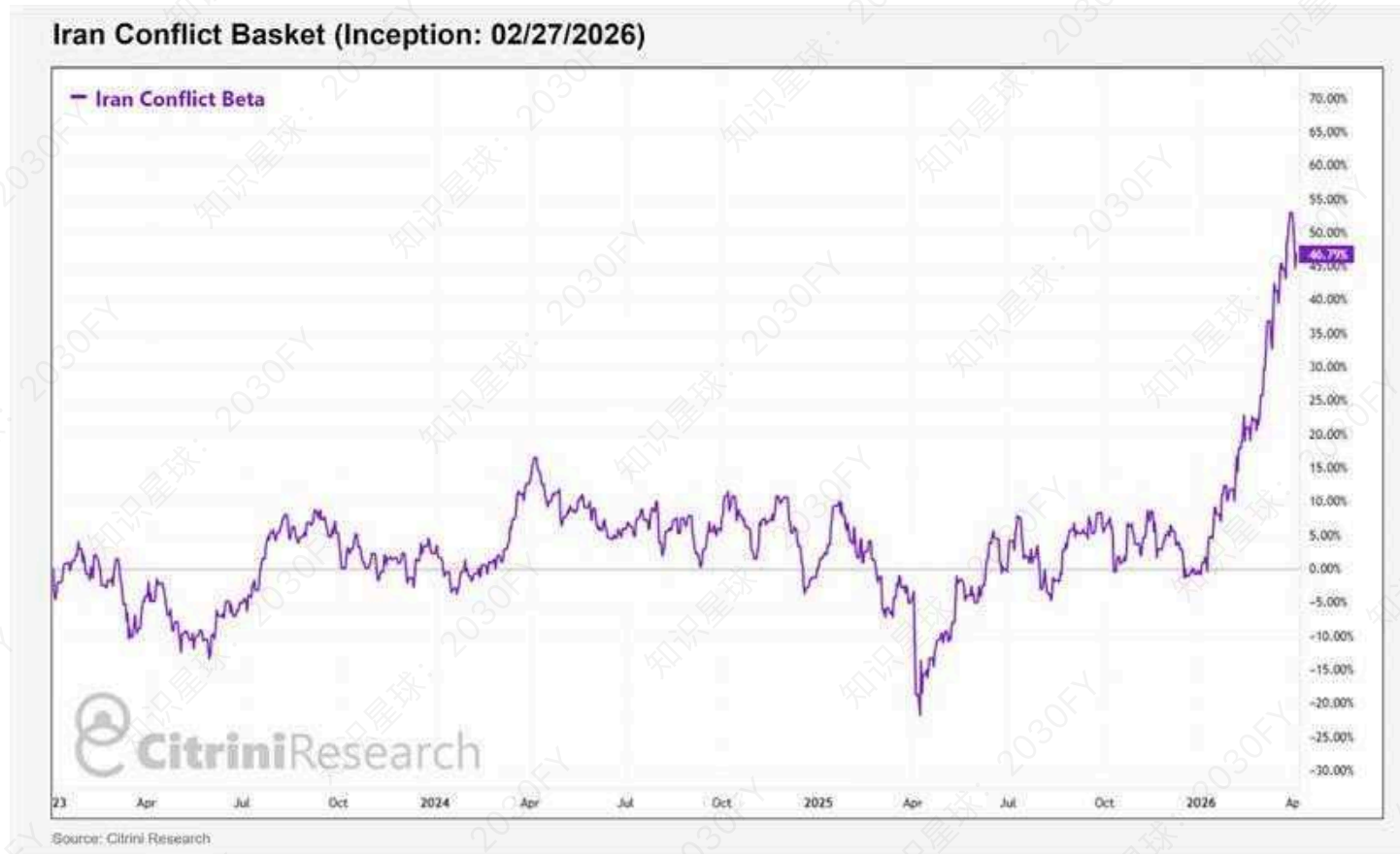
We feel that the tankers have yet to put a top in. In nearly every scenario, we see persistently elevated rates. Tanker companies are likely to continue printing money even if the Strait were to open completely tomorrow. Still, it's undeniable that with the momentum these names have picked up (BWET has more than quadrupled) there will be heightened volatility and they'll trade off of headlines in the short term

independent of their long term prospects.

我们认为油轮板块尚未见顶。在几乎所有情境下，我们都能看到运费持续处于高位。即便霍尔木兹海峡明天就完全开放，油轮公司也可能继续日进斗金。尽管如此，不可否认的是，随着这些标的势头走强（BWET 已翻了四倍多），波动性将会加剧，且短期内它们将脱离长期前景，转而随新闻头条波动。

That's why we created our expanded "Iran Conflict Beta" basket that we shared with subscribers in our chat here. This had a similar goal – how can we extrapolate *what has already happened* in terms of damage to facilities in order to put together a basket that will continue to benefit even if the conflict were resolved tomorrow.

这就是为什么我们创建了扩展版的“伊朗冲突 Beta”篮子，并已在聊天室中与订阅者分享。其目标与之前类似——即如何根据已经发生的设施损毁情况进行推演，从而构建一个即便冲突在明天得到解决，也能持续获益的投资组合。



Since inception, the basket has climbed +17%.

自成立以来，该投资组合已上涨了 17%。

It is clear from the majority of our conversations that the damage to oil refining and gas processing infrastructure has been significant and drastically underreported. Additionally, the refined products market is significantly tighter than the crude oil

market at the present moment – which is why this basket overweights refiners and products. However, we’re also expecting at least front month oil prices to go down as traffic opens back up. We feel the most asymmetric of these areas remains in US petrochemicals.

从我们的大多数对话中可以清楚地看到，石油精炼和天然气加工基础设施遭受的破坏非常严重，且被严重低估了。此外，目前成品油市场的紧张程度显著高于原油市场——这也是为什么该投资组合超配了炼油商和成品油相关资产的原因。然而，随着交通重新开放，我们预计至少近月原油价格将会下跌。我们认为，在这些领域中，美国石化行业依然最具不对称性机会。

We don’t feel enough conviction to forecast the short term direction for the US equity market, which is not solely a function of the outcome of this conflict. From a historical perspective, there’s a reasonable dispersion of outcomes.

我们没有足够的信心去预测美国股市的短期走势，因为这不仅仅取决于这场冲突的结果。从历史角度来看，结果的分布相当分散。

S&P 500 Performance During Major Geopolitical Conflicts

6-month forward returns and maximum intra-period drawdowns from conflict onset

Conflict	Start Date	S&P 500 at Start	S&P 500 at +6 Mo.	6-Month Return	Max Drawdown (Intra-Period)
World War II (Pearl Harbor)	Dec 8, 1941	8.97	8.47	-5.6%	-16.7%
Korean War	Jun 26, 1950	18.11	19.92	+10.0%	-7.9%
Vietnam War (Gulf of Tonkin)	Aug 3, 1964	83.00	87.58	+5.5%	-2.0%
Vietnam War (US Troops Deployed)	Mar 8, 1965	86.83	88.36	+1.8%	-6.0%
Cambodian Campaign (Vietnam)	Apr 29, 1970	81.81	83.36	+1.9%	-15.3%
Yom Kippur War / Oil Embargo	Oct 8, 1973	110.23	92.03	-16.5%	-17.8%
Iranian Hostage Crisis	Nov 5, 1979	101.82	106.38	+4.5%	-3.5%
Gulf War (Iraq Invades Kuwait)	Aug 2, 1990	351.48	343.05	-2.4%	-15.9%
Gulf War (Desert Storm Begins)	Jan 17, 1991	327.97	384.22	+17.2%	0.0%
War in Afghanistan (Post-9/11)	Sep 17, 2001	1,038.77	1,154.09	+11.1%	-7.0%
Iraq War	Mar 19, 2003	874.02	1,039.58	+18.9%	-3.0%
Russia Invades Crimea	Feb 27, 2014	1,854.29	2,003.37	+8.0%	-2.1%
Russia Invades Ukraine	Feb 24, 2022	4,288.70	4,057.66	-5.4%	-14.5%
Israel/US-Iran War	Jun 12, 2025	6,045.26	6,827.41	+12.9%	-1.3%
US-Iran Escalation	Mar 2, 2026	6,881.62	6,582.69*	-4.3%*	-7.8%

Source: Bloomberg, CitriniResearch | *Ongoing as of Apr 2026

Median 6-Mo. Return: +4.5% | Positive: 67% of conflicts

If we are wrong about the traffic in the strait continuing to trend upwards, and it goes back to being effectively closed rather than continuing to trend up through mid-late April it's very likely that global equities would go down significantly (~15-20%). Our base case right now is that equities will continue to experience heightened volatility as the conflict escalates and proceeds, but that concerns over a global energy crisis will give way to a more nuanced view of increased traffic through the strait with elevated

(but not catastrophic) prices in tandem.

如果我们对海峡交通流量持续回升的判断有误，且流量在4月中下旬未能继续增长而是转为有效关闭，那么全球股市极有可能大幅下跌（约15-20%）。我们目前的基本预测是，随着冲突的升级和持续，股市将继续经历剧烈波动，但对全球能源危机的担忧将让位于一种更细致的观点，即海峡交通流量将增加，同时伴随着处于高位（但非灾难性）的价格。

1. US Petrochemicals 1. 美国石化产品

Damage to Gulf petrochemical infrastructure has impacted this market structurally, and we see that coming up against a potential cyclical inflection that could make this the most asymmetric position. US petrochemical companies, who have uninterrupted access to cheap domestic feedstock, will greatly benefit from the global dislocation and surging prices.

海湾地区石化基础设施遭受的破坏已对该市场产生了结构性影响，我们认为这正迎来一个潜在的周期性拐点，可能使其成为最具不对称性的头寸。能够持续获得廉价国内原料的美国石化公司，将从全球供应错位和价格飙升中极大地受益。

“We were already beginning to see market signs of improvement in the first quarter before the Middle East conflict began. And now pricing actions and supply dynamics have evolved at a very rapid and constructive pace [...] and in March

already, we have announced price increases in every business in every region [...]

“在中东冲突爆发之前，我们已经开始看到第一季度市场出现好转的迹象。而现在，价格行动和供应动态正以非常迅速且建设性的步伐演变 [...] 就在 3 月份，我们已经宣布全球每个地区、每个业务部门的提价计划 [...]

Global logistics have become uncertain with **up to 50% of polyethylene supply either offline, constrained, or being impacted** following the events in the Middle East. In addition, inventory levels are historically low across the value chain.”

全球物流已变得充满不确定性，受中东局势影响，高达 50% 的聚乙烯供应处于停产、受限或受到冲击的状态。此外，整个价值链的库存水平正处于历史低位。”

- **Dow CEO James Fitterling, 3/18/26**

陶氏化学首席执行官 Jim Fitterling, 2026 年 3 月 18 日

Dow's polyethylene \$0.10 price hike in March, has been followed by a \$0.30 price hike in April (double the previously announced \$0.15 expectation).

陶氏化学 (Dow) 在 3 月份将聚乙烯价格上调了 0.10 美元，随后在 4 月份又上调了 0.30 美元（是此前预期的 0.15 美元的两倍）。



Seek Together



Dow Packaging & Specialty Plastics Price Update

Price Modification for April 2026

March 24, 2026

Dear Valued Customer,

The Dow Chemical Company and Dow Chemical Canada ULC ("Dow") will modify the previously announced US\$0.15/lb price increase to US\$0.30/lb for all HDPE/LLDPE/LDPE resins sold in the United States and Canada, respectively, effective April 1st, 2026, or as otherwise allowed by contract.

Your local Dow representative will contact you to answer any questions you may have regarding these price movements.

We appreciate your continued business.

Sincerely,

Izabel Assis
North America Commercial Vice President
Packaging and Specialty Plastics
The Dow Chemical Company

Global Environment Remains Dynamic

1Q Showing Modest Signs of Improvement in Some Areas ~~Following~~ the Beginning of the Middle East Conflict

- + Self-help actions continue to gain momentum, will build across 2026
- + YTD, NAA PE pricing is up; Industry inventory remains low across the value chain
- Monitoring post Lunar New Year trends in late March to assess potential impacts on demand in Asia
- Underlying global demand environment remains unchanged across key market verticals in most regions

2Q Margin Backdrop Inflecting ~~Following~~ the Beginning of the Middle East Conflict

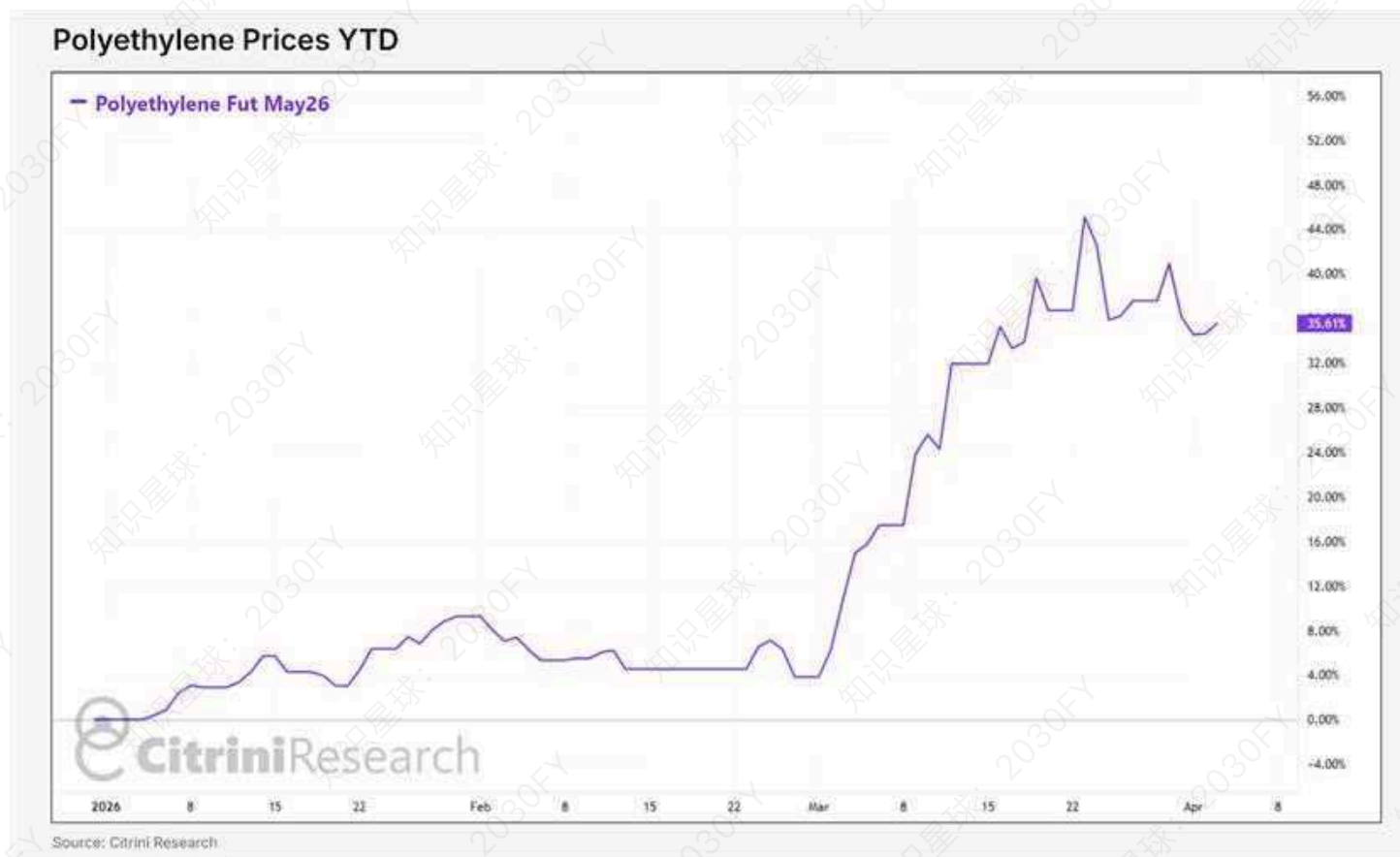
- + Geopolitical events could pressure 1Q margins, but should provide meaningful tailwinds to mid-year 2026 earnings
- + Positive price momentum expected heading into 2Q across Dow portfolio, entering traditional high seasonal demand period
- + Industry supply environment expected to show significant support via Middle East and Asian asset limitations
- Trade and tariff backdrop provides additional heightened near-term volatility



2

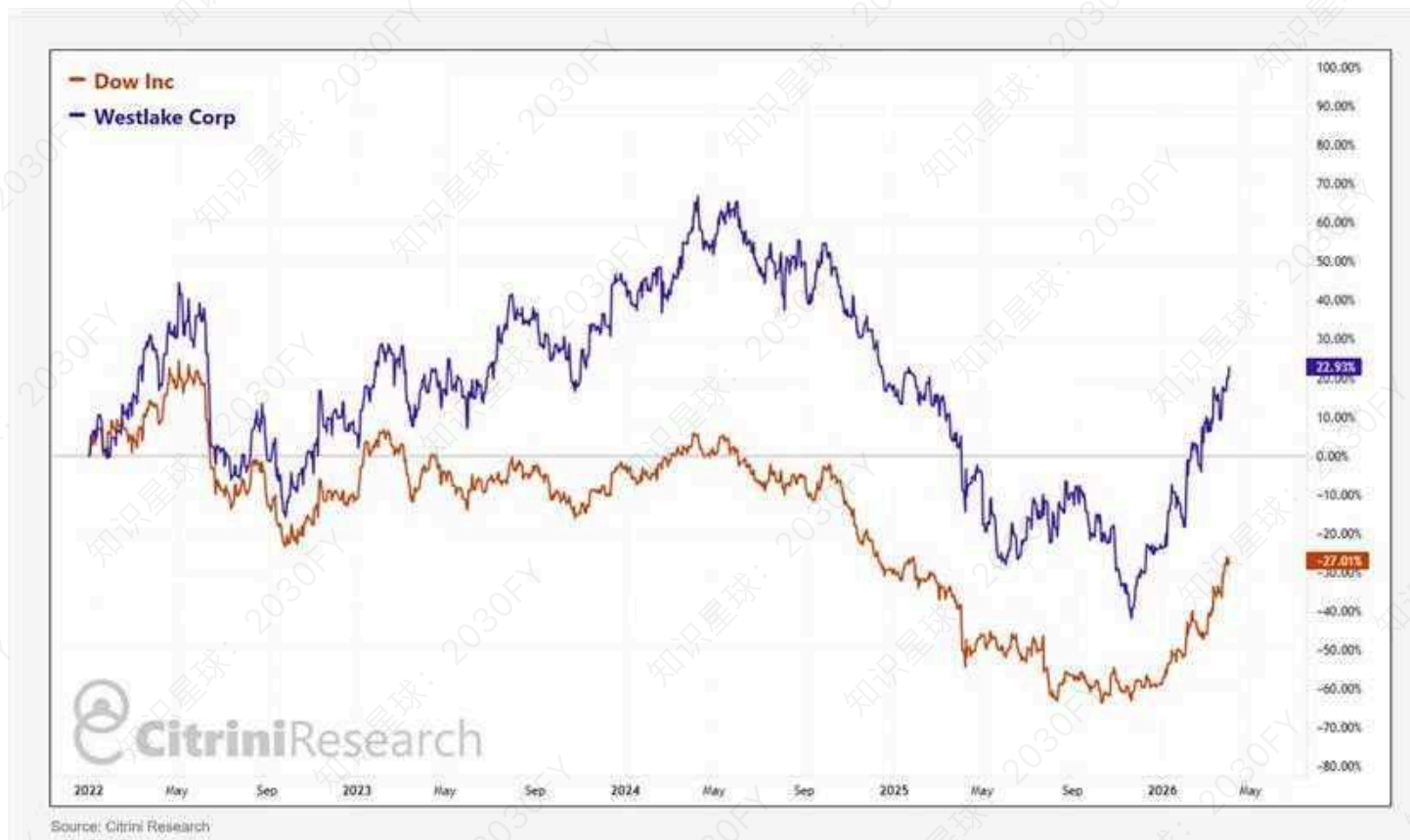
Last week, Dow's CEO James Fitterling predicted it could take 250 - 275 days for the supply to normalize even after the Strait of Hormuz reopens as shipments of oil, natural gas and fertilizer take priority.

上周，陶氏化学首席执行官詹姆斯·菲特林（James Fitterling）预测，即使在霍尔木兹海峡重新开放后，由于石油、天然气和化肥的运输具有优先权，供应可能也需要 250 到 275 天才能恢复正常。



The capacity destruction is real and the rebuild timeline is measured in years, not quarters. We opt for US-based producers who sit on the right side of this: Dow (DOW US) and Westlake (WLK US) are the primary positions.

产能的破坏是真实存在的，而重建的时间表是以年而非季度来衡量的。我们倾向于选择处于有利地位的美国生产商：陶氏化学（DOW US）和西湖化学（WLK US）是我们的主要持仓。



Even if the strait were to fully open tomorrow, we don't think prices are going back down to where they were before the conflict. That's pretty meaningful for stocks that are still in 50% drawdowns from their highs.

即使霍尔木兹海峡明天完全开放，我们也不认为价格会回落到冲突前的水平。对于那些仍较历史高点下跌 50% 的股票来说，这一点非常有意义。

2. Macroeconomic Situation

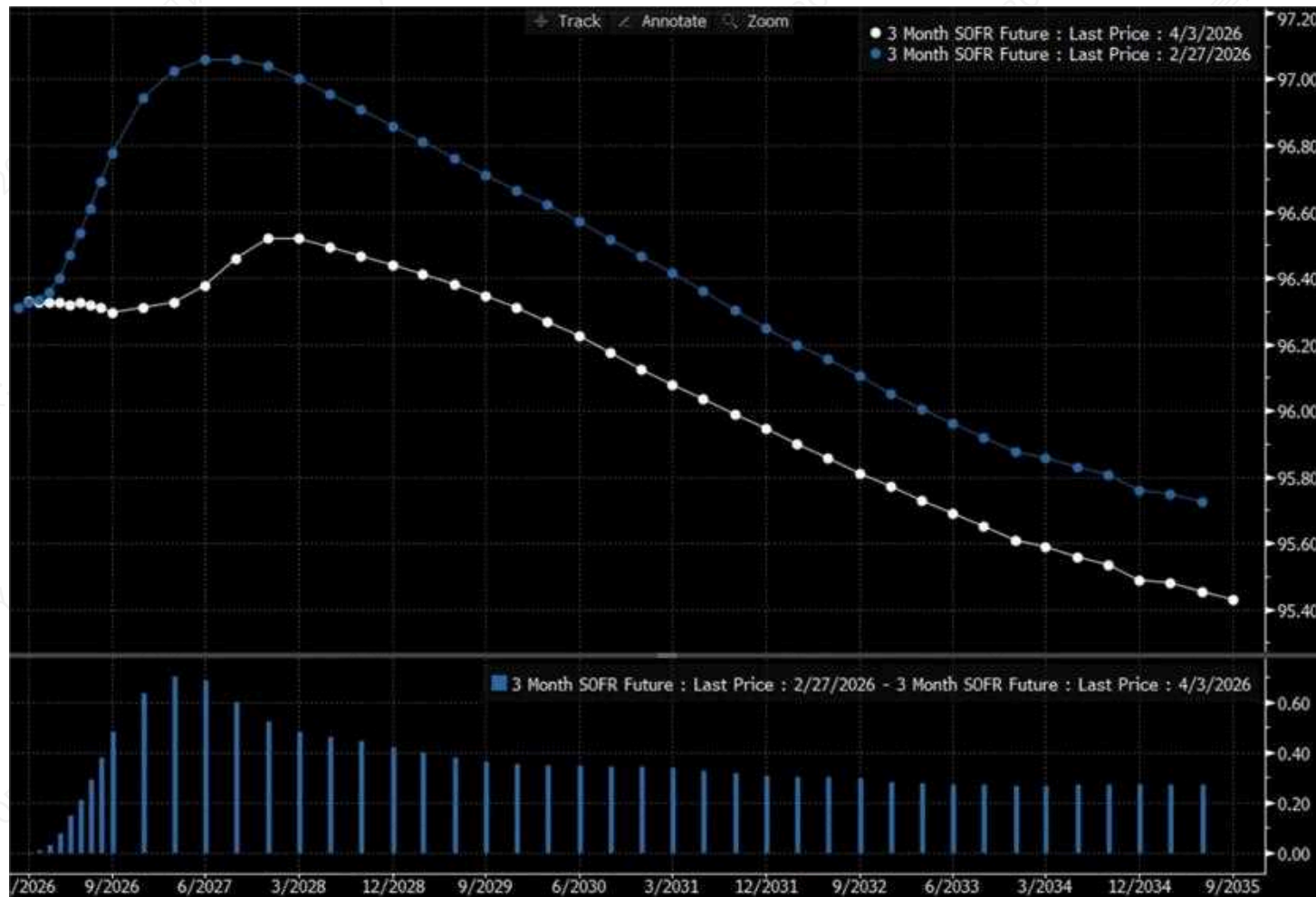
2. 宏观经济形势

2a. Short Term Interest Rates

2a. 短期利率

About two weeks ago, we put on a trade that pairs a short on ES with a long on SFRH7. We still feel that the Fed will look through the impact of the conflict and not rush to raise rates, but the overreaction that brought SFRH7 down to 96.05 has resolved somewhat and it now sits around 96.40. From here, we find the curve interesting.

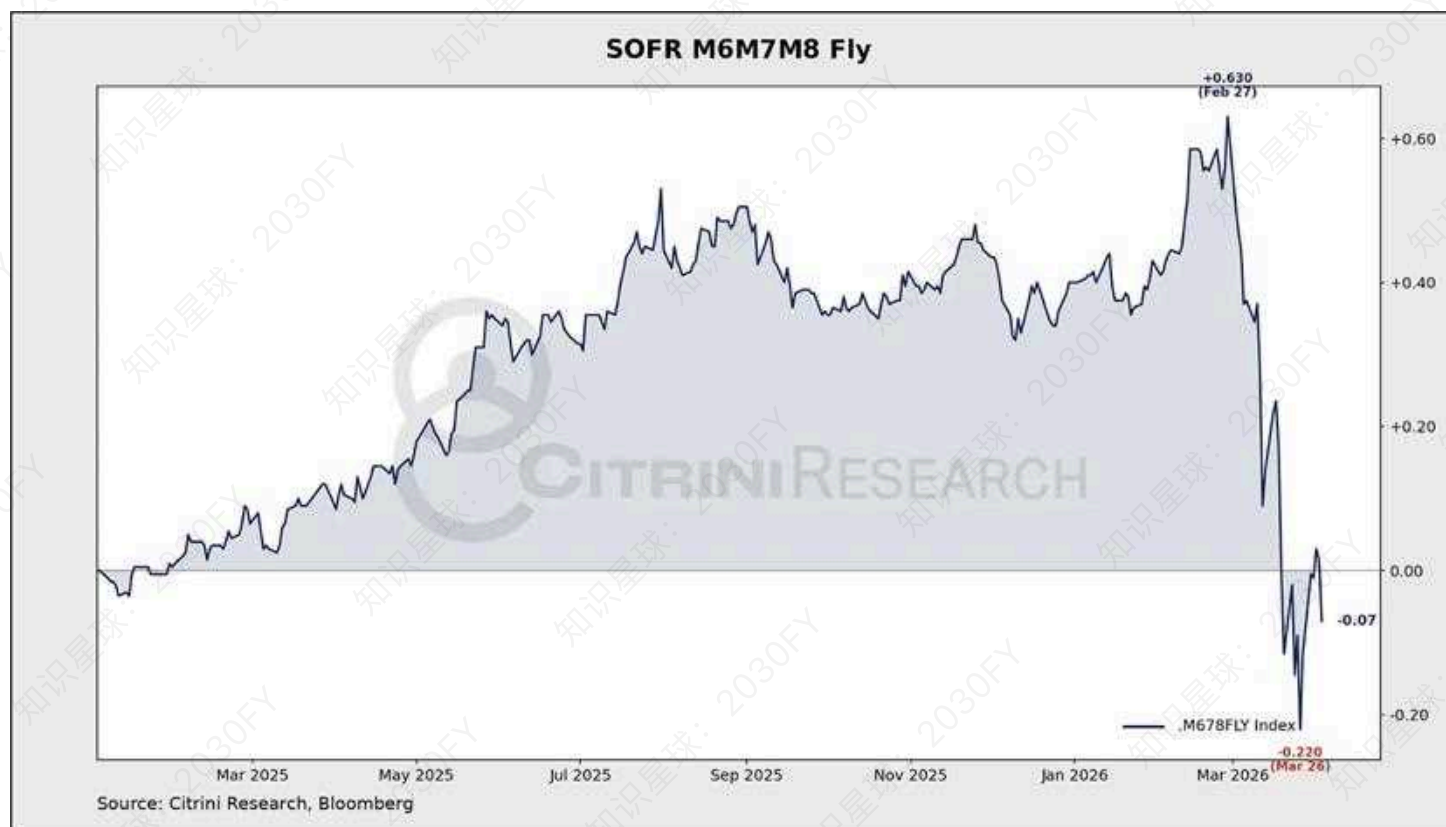
大约两周前，我们进行了一项交易，即做空 ES（标普 500 指数期货）同时做多 SFRH7。我们仍然认为美联储会看淡冲突的影响，不会急于加息，但之前将 SFRH7 推低至 96.05 的过度反应已有所缓解，目前处于 96.40 左右。从这个位置来看，我们认为收益率曲线很有意思。



Before the conflict broke out, the SFRM6-SFRM7-SFRM8 fly had priced in nearly 3 more rate cuts between M6 and M7 than M7 and M8 – now that’s 0. Playing for cuts to be pulled forward again seems asymmetric, as fears of global inflation due to strait closure ease and any potential for longer term impacts to weaken the economy and

pull forward cuts.

在冲突爆发之前，SFRM6-SFRM7-SFRM8 的蝶式价差反映出 M6 到 M7 之间的降息次数比 M7 到 M8 之间多出近 3 次——而现在这个差值是 0。再次博弈降息提前似乎具有不对称性，因为对海峡关闭引发全球通胀的担忧正在缓解，而任何潜在的长期影响都可能削弱经济并导致降息提前。



2b. Relative Country-Level Positioning

2b. 相对国家级定位

As we mentioned earlier, we are too acutely aware of the trigger finger investors have when it relates to stocks and headlines right now to make a very near term call on the direction of equity indices. *However*, we're pretty content to do so on a relative basis.

正如我们之前提到的，我们非常清楚投资者目前对股票和头条新闻的反应极其敏感，因此无法对股票指数的短期走势做出判断。然而，我们非常乐意在相对基础上进行预测。

It's a bit more complex than just "who's got the least reserves" if we're expecting any sort of continued reopening. And if we want to position in a way where this toll solution is the way things proceed for the time being, we should also add in a lens that views things through diplomatic relations.

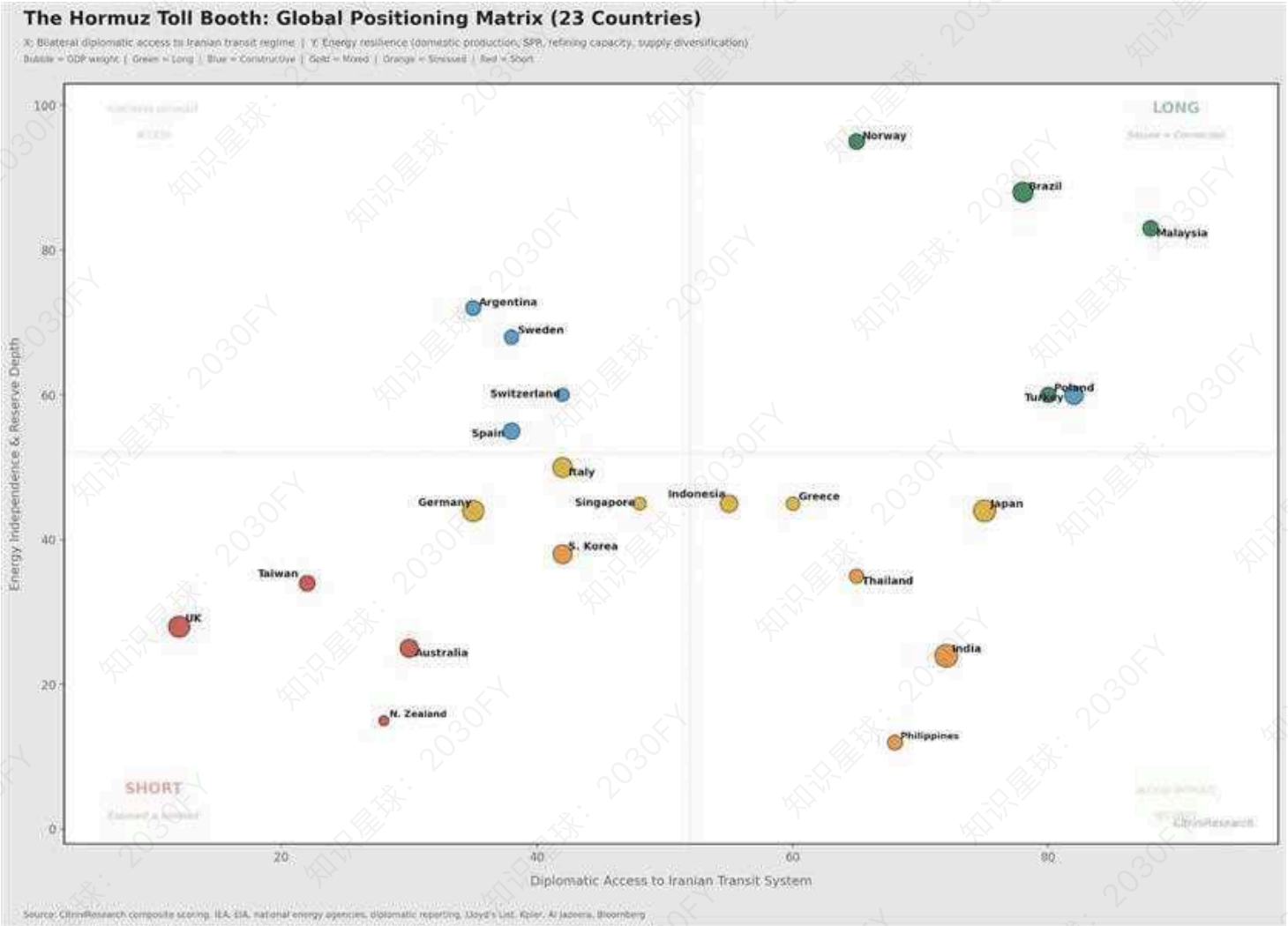
如果我们预期会有任何形式的持续重新开放，情况会比单纯看“谁的储备最少”要复杂一些。如果我们想在当前这种“通行费方案”持续运作的情况下进行布局，我们还应该加入一个外交关系的视角。

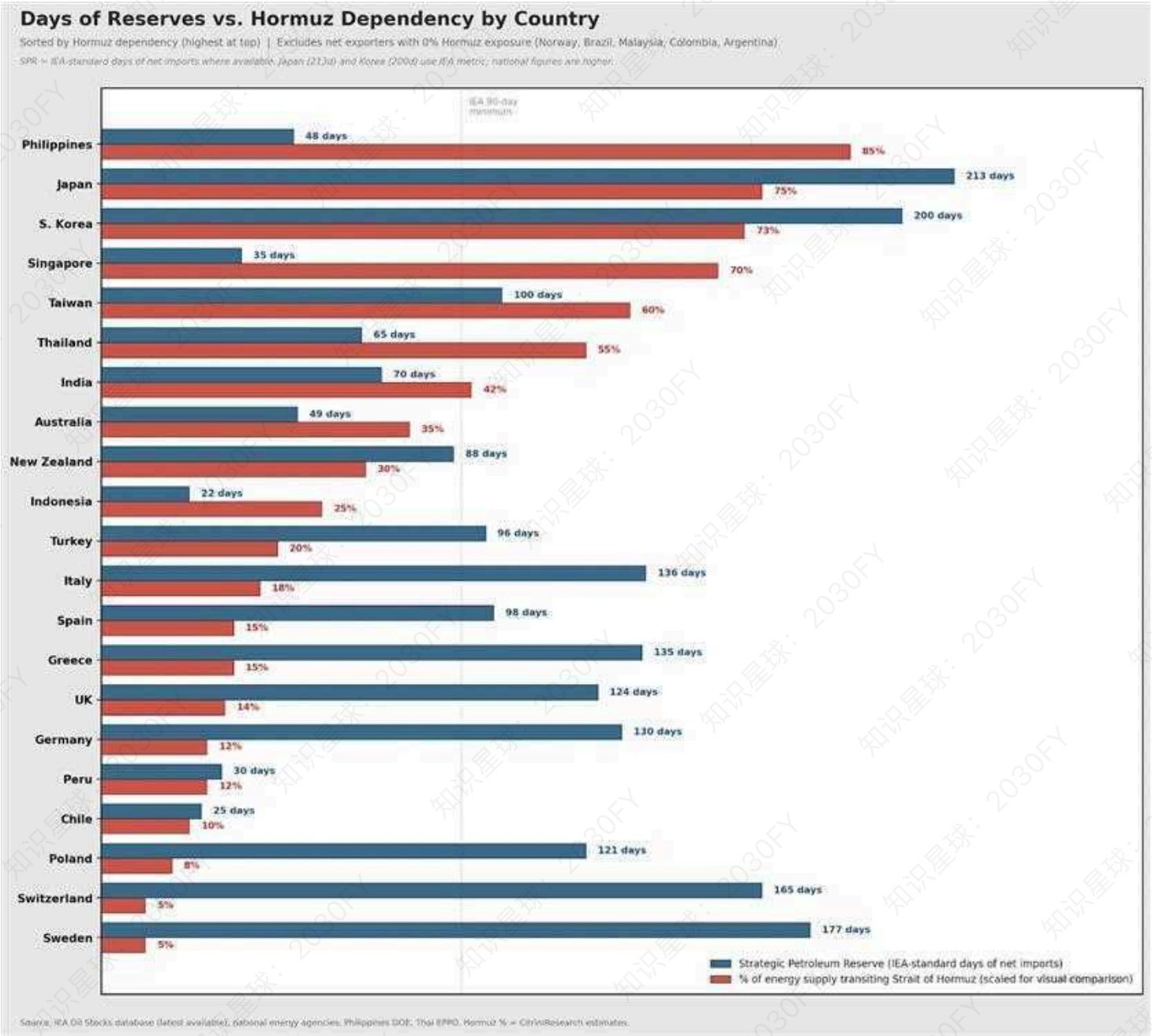
- Level of Energy Security (measured by energy imports going through the strait, size and composition of strategic reserves)

能源安全水平（通过通过海峡的能源进口量、战略储备的规模和构成来衡量）。

- Willingness to “Play Ball” with whoever controls the Strait (if they’ve already negotiated to get ships through, that’s a good sign they’ll be able to navigate however this plays out. If they’ve expressed unwillingness to do so, especially in light of criteria A being weak, they’re probably worse off)

与海峡控制方“通力合作”的意愿（如果他们已经通过谈判让船只通过，这是一个好迹象，表明无论局势如何发展，他们都能应对自如。如果他们表现出不愿合作，特别是考虑到标准 A 较弱的情况下，他们的处境可能会更糟）。





A few potential country long/short pairs that fall out of this analysis naturally:

从这一分析中自然得出的一些潜在国家做多/做空组合:

- **Long Norway / Short Australia** (net exporter with no chokepoint vs. net exporter that can't refine its own fuel)

做多挪威 / 做空澳大利亚 (无咽喉要道限制的净出口国 vs. 无法自行炼油的净出口国)

- **Long Malaysia / Short India** (terms-of-trade transfer, both have diplomatic access, opposite energy positions)

做多马来西亚 / 做空印度 (贸易条件转移, 两者均拥有外交准入, 但能源头寸相反)

- **Long Poland / Short UK** (European energy security divergence, diplomatic neutrality vs. leading the opposition)

做多波兰 / 做空英国 (欧洲能源安全分歧, 外交中立 vs. 领导反对派)

- **Long Japan / Short Korea** (diplomatic execution gap - Japan has the most friendly relations with Iran out of any of the G7, same structural exposure, different crisis management)

做多日本 / 做空韩国 (外交执行力差异——日本在 G7 国家中与伊朗的关系最为友好, 两者结构性风险敞口相同, 但危机管理能力不同)

- **Long Turkey / Short Germany** (European energy corridor vs. European energy consumer, mediator vs. bystander)

做多土耳其 / 做空德国 (欧洲能源走廊 vs. 欧洲能源消费者, 调解人 vs. 旁观者)

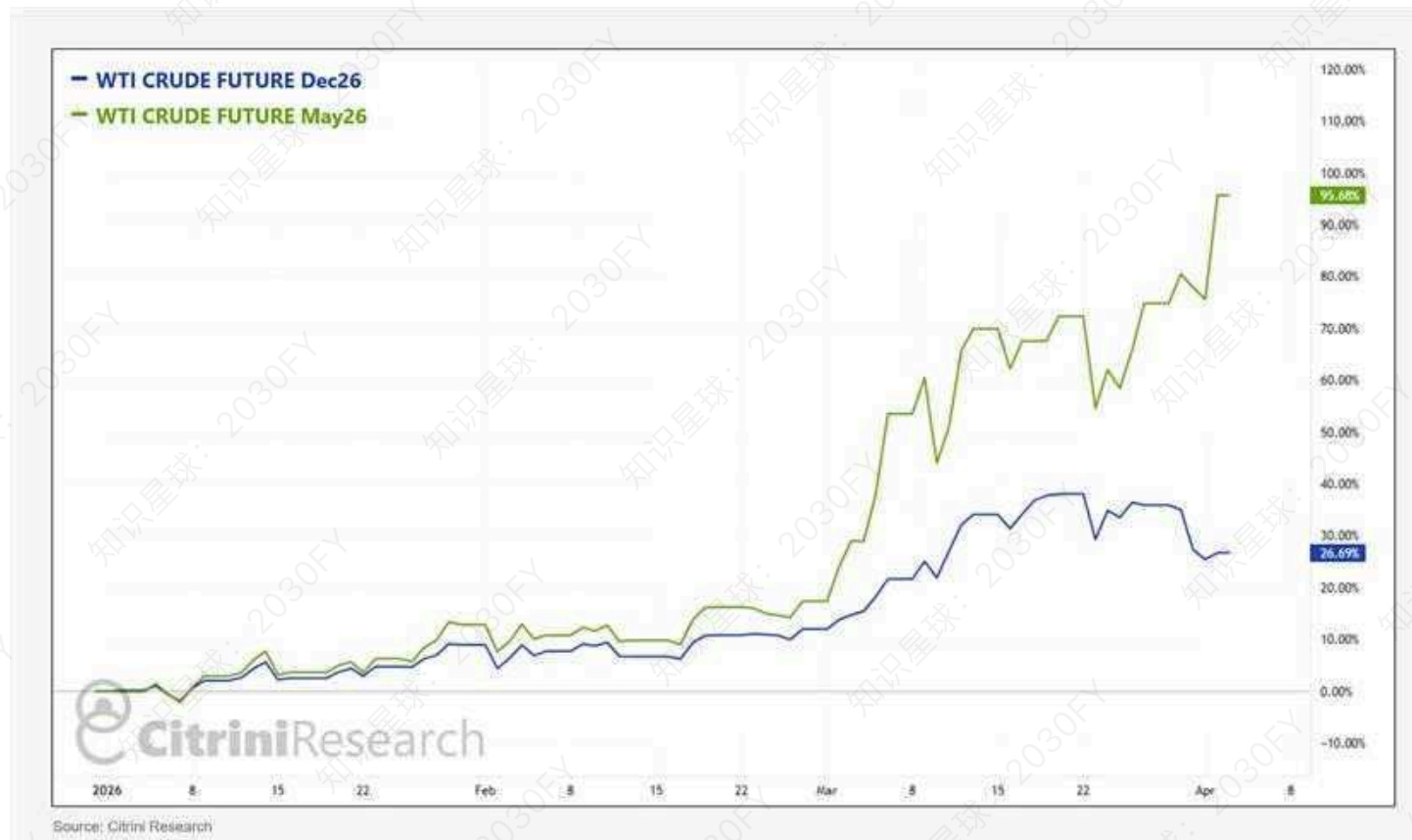
3. Long CLZ6/Short Front Month:

3. 做多 CLZ6 / 做空近月合约:

This should drive home that what we've described as our view of the conflict is nuanced – it doesn't fit neatly into “strait open crude down” or “strait closed crude parabolic”. We think long December 2026 WTI crude works well from here, and would ultimately be on the lookout to put on long CLZ6 versus short front month. We have to caution that we'd keep a tight stop on the front month leg given the potential for nonlinear developments associated with a ground operation (or simply wait to put it on), which could spike the front end in ways that hurt the short leg before the thesis plays out. The front month at \$110 and December 2026 at \$71 tells you the market is

pricing a short, sharp disruption.

这应该能让我们更深刻地理解，我们对这场冲突的看法是细致入微的——它并不简单地等同于“海峡开放则原油下跌”或“海峡关闭则原油抛物线式上涨”。我们认为，从目前来看，做多 2026 年 12 月的 WTI 原油期货表现会很好，并最终会寻求建立“多 CLZ6 对冲空近月合约”的头寸。我们需要提醒的是，考虑到与地面行动相关的非线性发展潜力（或者干脆等待时机再入场），我们会对近月合约头寸设置严格的止损，因为近月合约可能会在逻辑兑现前出现暴涨，从而伤及空头头寸。近月合约在 110 美元而 2026 年 12 月合约在 71 美元，这一现象告诉我们的是一场短暂且剧烈的供应中断。



We think the disruption is longer and the new normal involves a permanent risk premium, but that we'll likely see as high as 50% of pre-conflict traffic within the next 4-6 weeks. We'll be looking for opportunistic adds to build this position, and we're

already long CLZ2026 in our macro trade list.

我们认为干扰将持续更久，且“新常态”将包含永久性的风险溢价，但在接下来的 4 到 6 周内，我们可能会看到交通量恢复到冲突前水平的 50%。我们将寻找机会加仓以建立该头寸，并且在我们的宏观交易名单中已经做多 CLZ2026。

4. EU and Japan Energy Independence + Defense:

4. 欧盟和日本的能源独立与国防:

Regardless of how this conflict resolves, the new paradigm where the US has left its allies to fend for themselves will result in more fiscal spending directed towards both energy independence and defense.

无论这场冲突如何解决，美国任由盟友自生自灭的新范式都将导致更多的财政支出流向能源独立和国防领域。

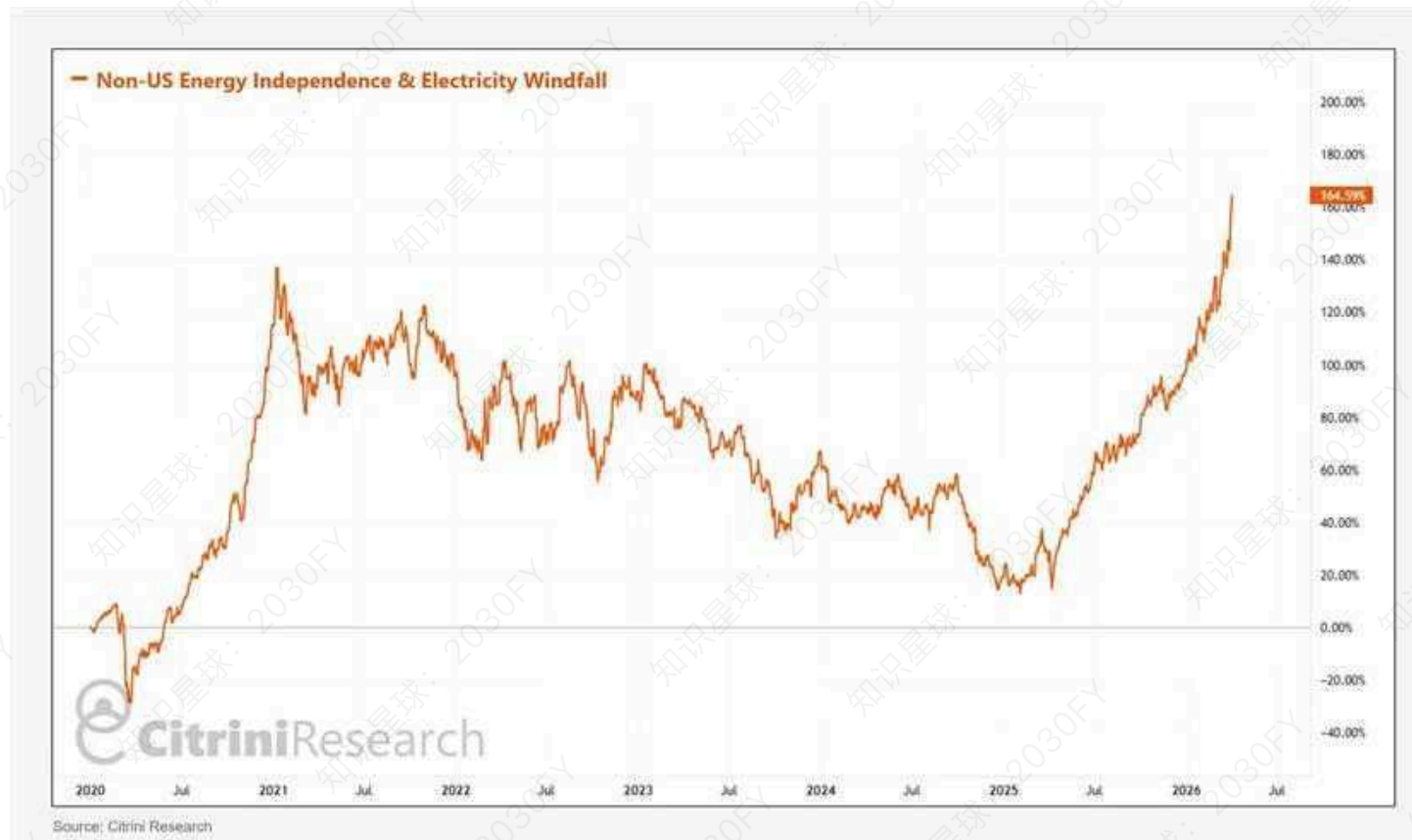
Every ceasefire rumor that knocks these names down is an opportunity. The structural shift in European and Japanese energy and defense policy is permanent whether Hormuz reopens next week or next year. It feels asymmetric to buy dips caused by headlines about resolution or deals. An easy expression of this is the **Europe**

Aerospace and Defense ETF (EUAD US)

每一个因停火传闻而导致这些标地下跌的时机都是机会。无论霍尔木兹海峡是下周还是明年重新开放，欧洲和日本能源及国防政策的结构性转变都是永久性的。逢低买入由和谈或协议传闻引起的下跌，这种操作具有不对称性。对此最简单的表达方式是买入欧洲航空航天与国防 ETF (EUAD US)。

At the same time, both the EU and Japan will be focused on ensuring that they move towards securing energy independence – this will motivate their fiscal spending. Additionally, many companies with upside to such a trend also will benefit from any windfall due to higher electricity prices (especially where the price of electricity is primarily dictated by the price of gas). This provides an asymmetry in which the strait having a more gradual reopening is beneficial, but the simple fact that the world is becoming more multipolar and US security guarantees are less assured is enough to get this moving.

与此同时，欧盟和日本都将致力于确保迈向能源独立——这将激发其财政支出。此外，许多能从这一趋势中获益的公司也将从高电价带来的意外收益中分得一杯羹（尤其是在电价主要由天然气价格决定的地区）。这提供了一种不对称性：霍尔木兹海峡更缓慢地重新开放是有利的，但仅凭世界正变得更加多极化以及美国的安全保障不再那么可靠这一事实，就足以推动这一进程。



We have assembled a basket / watchlist of companies that we feel fit this description in the EU and Japan:

我们整理了一份我们认为符合上述描述的欧盟和日本公司的篮子/观察名单:

Energy Sovereignty Basket		
Company	Ticker	Rationale
Fortum	FORTUM FH	Near-zero cost hydro/nuclear fleet sells into gas-set wholesale. EUR 9.7/MWh optimisation premium from timing hydro dispatch into peak hours.
RWE	RWE GR	~30 GW renewables + flexible gas plants. Profits on both sides of the merit order: renewables capture clearing prices, gas fleet captures spark spreads.
SMA Solar	S92 GR	Every solar panel in Europe needs an inverter. Order books expand with fast-tracked buildout. Battery storage inverter exposure adds a second vector.
Neste	NESTE FH	World's largest renewable diesel producer. Stock -35% after ME escalation early 2026. Crude spikes narrow the fossil-to-renewable diesel spread.
Iberdrola	IBE SQ	Europe's largest utility — ~60% EBITDA from regulated networks anchors earnings; renewable fleet captures wholesale on unhedged volumes. EUR 6.3B net profit '25.
Acciona Energia	ANE SQ	+12 GW wind/solar/hydro, heavy Iberian merchant exposure. Depressed multiples vs. installed capacity. Purer wholesale price bet than Iberdrola.
EDP Renovaveis	EDPR PL	~16 GW operational, Europe's largest renewable developer. Morningstar FV EUR 13 vs ~EUR 7.50 trading. European assets capture gas-set clearing prices.
Nordex	NDX1 GR	Onshore wind turbines, the segment fastest to permit and build. More leveraged to European volume growth than Vestas.
Scatec	SCATC NO	~4.6 GW in emerging markets where tariffs benchmark to fossil costs. Higher oil/gas prices improve relative economics for every new bid.
Redeia	RED SQ	Spain's grid operator. EUR 6.5B capex through 2029. Every new renewable MW in Iberia needs a grid connection. Regulated returns, accelerating cycle.
Verbio	VBK SY	Bioethanol, biodiesel, biomethane. Stock +19% on conflict escalation. CEO: rising fuel prices "extraordinarily beneficial." Biomethane subs for Russian gas.
Verbund	VER AV	~67% hydro at near-zero marginal cost into gas-set Austrian wholesale. Avg. sale EUR 116.3/MWh in '25; EBITDA EUR 2.74B despite drought year.
Renova	9519 JP	Japanese renewable IPP: solar, biomass, wind, hydro. Japan imports ~10% of primary energy. Domestic generation is a national security line item.
GS Yuasa	6674 JP	Battery manufacturer for storage and autos. Storage is the missing link for integrating intermittent renewables and displacing gas peakers.
Drax	DRX LN	UK biomass/hydro baseload. Higher gas prices widen the spread between fossil and biomass generation. Capacity market payments provide floor.
West Holdings	1407 JP	Japanese solar developer. Feed-in tariff regime and generation-displacing renewables targets built to reduce import dependence.
Vestas	VWS DC	World's largest wind turbine OEM. EUR 735M operating profit FY2025, beat guidance. Order intake tracks government capacity target announcements.
Orsted	ORSTED DC	Global offshore wind leader. Large-scale domestic generation displacing imported gas. Accelerated permitting is the catalyst.
Greenergy	GRE SQ	"Merchant 58 PPA" solar + storage developer. ~30% merchant exposure. Storage shifts solar output into higher priced hours.
Solaria	SLR SQ	Spanish solar IPP. 25% merchant FY24 moving to 100%. Purer Iberian wholesale price play. Adding 516 MWh battery storage for intraday arb.
Northland Power	NPI CN	Major European offshore wind (Gemini, Deutsche Bucht, Nordsee One) with direct wholesale price exposure to European energy markets.

Source: CitriniResearch



Broader Thematic Implications 更广泛的主题影响

This will be messy, it will require nuance – even the reaction on Twitter to our post about observing more ships going through the Strait had reactions that deemed that impossible because the conflict was ongoing. People will need to change their binary frameworks.

这将是一个复杂且需要细致入微观察的过程——甚至我们在推特上发布关于观察到更多船只通过海峡的帖子时，也有反应认为这不可能，因为冲突仍在继续。人们需要改变他们非黑即白的思维框架。

Still, the Iran conflict is just one block in the new world order that's been building up for the past decade. It's more complex than “*declining American hegemony*” and more complicated than “*every country spends more money on defense and energy*”. As alliances become negotiable, situational, transactional, and states no longer wait for a single hegemon to restore order, there will be wide ranging investment implications.

尽管如此，伊朗冲突只是过去十年中不断构建的新世界秩序中的一块拼图。它比“美国霸权的衰落”更复杂，也比“各国在国防和能源上投入更多资金”更深奥。随着联盟变得可协商、情境化和交易化，且各国不再等待单一霸权来恢复秩序，这将产生广泛的投资影响。

This doesn't stop here - Venezuela, Iran, Cuba...they are all part of a broader strategy that ends with a very different looking world.

这并不会就此停止——委内瑞拉、伊朗、古巴.....它们都是一项更宏大战略的一部分，而这一战略最终将指向一个面貌迥异的世界。

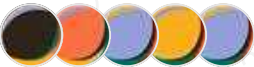
What should we be putting on our radar right now? Things like what the world looks like if Iranian sanctions get dropped or Cuba becomes part of the US or the EU acts more like a bloc. The conflict angle is paradoxically the smallest part of the story compared to what happens when every country on both sides of the strait starts behaving like a sovereign actor with its own balance sheet to protect. That shift changes how investors should think about security, industrial policy, and the winners and losers from a slow reorganization of the prevailing world order. That is the subject of our upcoming thematic primer, *Age of Empires*.

For now, we are content with what we've learned on our excursion. Analyst #3 is safe and ready for the next one.

We feel, for the first time since this conflict began, that we can more confidently assess the extent of the risks and more clearly define the potential outcomes and probabilities thereof. We didn't think we'd come out of this with a more optimistic view, but the reality is it's hard to go anywhere but up when your view is a prolonged and total closure of one of the most vital waterways for energy on Earth. The complex

reality is that the Strait is not fully closed and is likely to see traffic pick up, but that the conflict is unlikely to resolve neatly and quickly. That's difficult to translate into the next 100 points for SPX, but it's what's happening.

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Alex Kramar 5h

"dubbed Analyst #3 in order to avoid emotional attachment"

Too late.

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Daniel Saedi 4h

This piece is so good

LIKE (3) REPLY

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